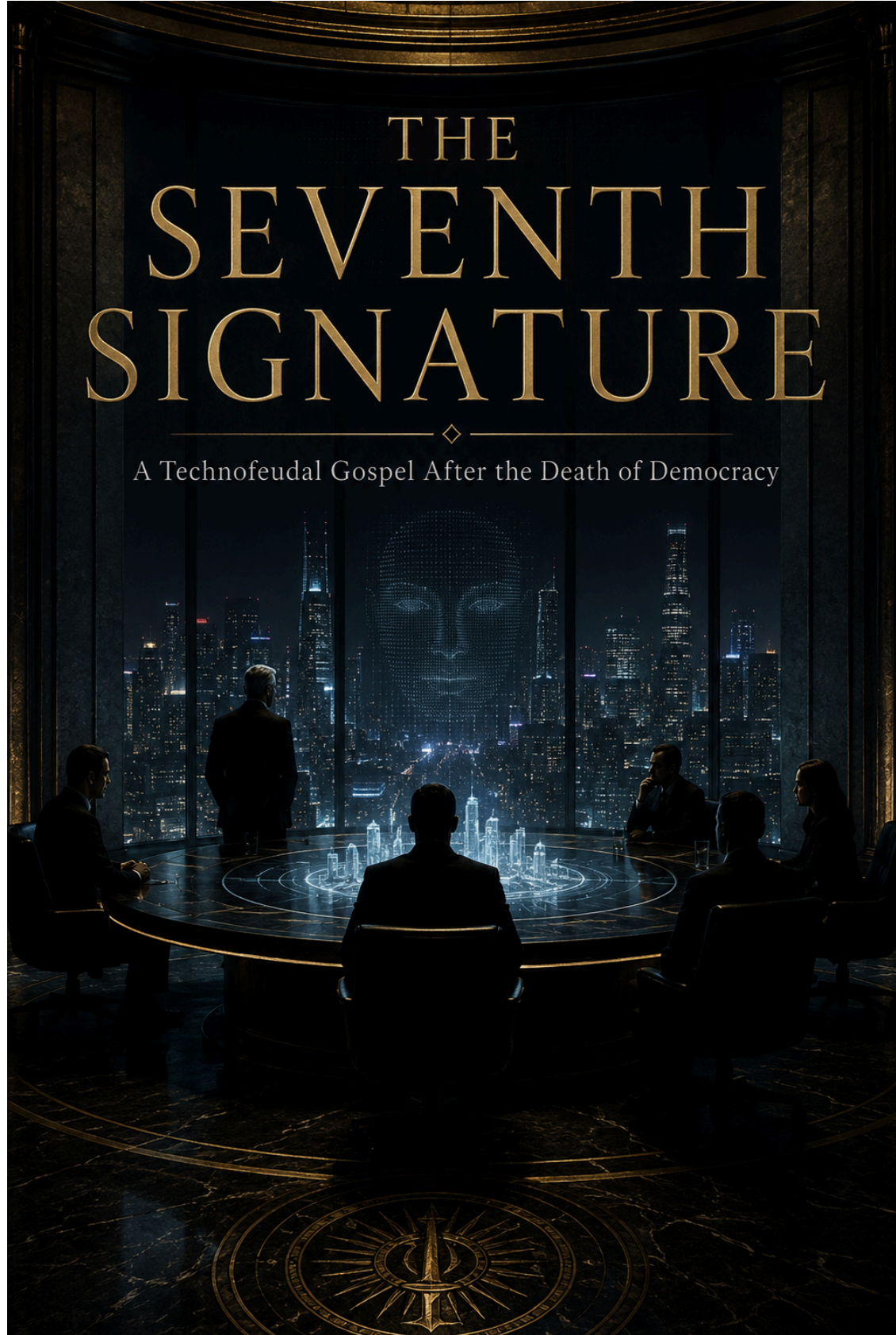


THE SEVENTH SIGNATURE

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A Technofeudal Gospel After the Death of Democracy



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Author's Note

This work was created under the umbrella of Axiologic Research as part of two interconnected research programs, one dedicated to Artificial Intelligence and the other to Outfinitism, both led by Sînică Alboaie. To explore the details of how these two programs intersect and build upon each other, we invite readers to visit the Outfinity Venture Studio page at www.outfinity.ch.

While Artificial Intelligence language models were used to assist with text generation, the foundational philosophy, thematic structure, and analytical approach derive exclusively from the author's decades of dedicated study of social phenomena, social technologies, and genuine hard technologies resulting from various European and self funded research projects. Recently, within the Achilles research project, we have been deeply studying AI generated literature and its automated verification using neuro symbolic approaches; all the free books made available to the public are part of the suite of works we use to test our latest technologies.

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PREFACE

A stronger argument is more dangerous than a loud one

The easiest way to imagine the end of liberal democracy is also the least useful. One pictures soldiers in the streets, a suspended constitution, a television address, a frightened parliament, and a ruler who announces that liberty has become an inconvenience. History contains enough examples to make the picture plausible. It is nevertheless an inadequate model for a technological civilization in which power is increasingly exercised through systems that do not look political at all.

A cloud contract can matter more to a hospital than a campaign promise. An identity provider can determine whether a person exists for an institution. A payments network can turn legal property into inaccessible property. A logistics platform can decide whether food, medicine, batteries, or spare parts arrive before a public authority has even convened a committee. An artificial intelligence system can become the layer through which millions of decisions are interpreted without ever receiving the title of judge. In such a world, sovereignty can migrate without a coup because formal sovereignty and operational sovereignty are no longer the same thing.

This book is built around that possibility. It does not assume that the transition is inevitable, and its characters are fictional. But their arguments begin from real tensions. Freedom House reported in 2026 that global freedom had declined for a twentieth consecutive year. V-Dem described a long wave of autocratization reaching even established democracies. The World Justice Project reported in 2025

that rule-of-law performance had declined in a large majority of the jurisdictions it measured, with particularly broad deterioration in civic participation, freedom of expression, and institutional checks. At the same time, the infrastructure of artificial intelligence was becoming more concentrated and more capital-intensive. Stanford's 2026 AI Index reported that industry produced more than ninety percent of notable AI models in 2025 and that frontier capability increasingly depended on compute and data infrastructures controlled by a small number of firms. Regulators in the United Kingdom and the European Union were already treating cloud concentration and switching barriers as matters of strategic power rather than ordinary consumer choice.

None of these observations proves technofeudalism. Indeed, the term itself is contested. Yanis Varoufakis uses it to describe a shift from profit toward forms of digital rent and platform dependence; Evgeny Morozov and others argue that the language of feudalism can obscure the continuing logic of capitalism. The disagreement matters. The order imagined here is not medieval Europe with data centers. It is a possible topology of power in which control of indispensable infrastructure creates durable, asymmetric obligations; exit becomes expensive; private rule acquires territorial and personal consequences; and political institutions gradually become customers of systems they once regulated.

The Council in this book therefore does not begin by declaring ordinary people inferior. It begins by asking narrower questions. Who is actually capable of keeping a complex civilization running through long emergencies? Who pays for errors made by voters who will never bear their full consequences? What does consent mean when every available alternative uses the same identity, compute, payment, and logistics substrate? At what point does an emergency concession

become a constitution? Can equal moral worth imply equal authority over technical systems? Can universal rights survive if institutions lack the material capacity to enforce them? Can an artificial intelligence remain a tool when no human actor can independently reproduce the reasoning on which the system depends?

The six people who answer these questions do not think of themselves as villains. That is essential. They believe they are finishing a transition that the old order began but refused to name. For most of the book they agree on more than they disagree on. Their doctrine is severe, hierarchical, and eventually post-liberal, but it is not built out of theatrical cruelty. It is built out of continuity plans, contracts, insurance models, security protocols, infrastructure dependencies, intergenerational accounting, and a philosophy of human improvement.

Only in the final chapter are the deepest weaknesses of their construction examined directly. They are not weaknesses because the old liberal order was pure, competent, or victorious. They are weaknesses because any regime that claims superiority must survive its own standards. A doctrine of unequal authority must explain who measures superiority. A system built on prediction must remain capable of discovering that its models are wrong. A culture of self-overcoming must explain why its successors should obey its founders. A private federation must explain why the institution that coordinates the sovereigns is not itself the sovereign. And a civilization that discards universal rights must account for the possibility that rights were not merely gifts to the weak, but error-correcting constraints on the powerful.

The argument is deliberately allowed to become as strong as it can before those questions are asked. A weak technofeudalism is easy to reject. A competent one is more revealing.

PROLOGUE — THE QUIET TRANSFER

The centenary

On the morning of 10 December 2048, a century after the adoption of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, the public square outside the Palais des Nations in Geneva was almost full.

That fact would later be misremembered.

The old story said that nobody came. It was convenient because it made abandonment visible. In reality, tens of thousands came. They stood beneath cold rain with transparent umbrellas, projected the thirty articles of the Declaration onto the wet stone, and listened to speeches in dozens of languages. Schools sent classes. Unions sent delegations. Human-rights organizations filled the tram lines. For a few hours the city looked like a capital of a political world that still existed.

The difficulty was that the commemoration had no object capable of obeying it.

The General Assembly had not repealed the Declaration. Most national constitutions still contained catalogues of rights. The European Court of Human Rights continued to issue judgments, as did constitutional courts across the continent. International committees still met, published observations, and supervised implementation. The vocabulary survived with remarkable durability.

What had changed was the chain between a declared right and a material outcome.

A right to medical treatment meant little if the regional hospital could not obtain compute credits from the diagnostic network. A judicial order to restore an account meant little if identity federation had migrated to a private clearing layer outside the court's technical jurisdiction. A right to movement became abstract when transport access, insurance validity, and payment authorization were all conditioned by the same risk architecture. A municipality could legally authorize a shelter and still discover that the energy microgrid had no capacity reservation for it. A parliament could forbid automated employment scoring and then learn that every major employer depended on cross-border insurance contracts that required precisely such scoring.

Nothing had disappeared. Everything had acquired a dependency.

Elias Dorne watched the centenary ceremony from a window three streets away. He had once argued cases before international courts. He had spent the middle of his career designing enforcement protocols for rights judgments, and the last decade studying why those protocols increasingly produced legal victory without operational consequence.

He was seventy-four and disliked the phrase post-liberal because it made history sound like an academic seminar. He preferred a more humiliating description.

The institutions had not been defeated. They had become upstream of nothing.

His wrist terminal showed a message from the Council's security layer.

**TRANSPORT WINDOW CONFIRMED. DEPARTURE 14:20.
IDENTITY TOKEN VALID FOR SIX HOURS. DESTINATION
CLASSIFIED UNTIL TRANSFER.**

Dorne closed it.

At the square, a young woman was reading Article 1 aloud: human beings were born free and equal in dignity and rights. Her voice was carried by a public-address system leased from a media platform. The stream was authenticated by a private identity federation, distributed by a private content network, and stored in a private archival cloud. The police perimeter relied on a threat-detection service supplied by Kade Security. The city had purchased emergency power reserves from Vale Infrastructure. The health tents were insured through Arcos Mutual. Even the protest against private power was physically possible because private power had guaranteed continuity for the event.

Dorne did not find this ironic. Irony was too small a category.

He found it constitutional.

The practical constitution of a society, he had begun to think, was the set of systems whose refusal could stop ordinary life.

At 14:20 a car collected him. It contained no driver. The windows became opaque as soon as he entered the motorway.

DORNE: "Where are we going?"

ORISON: "To the Susten Continuity Facility."

DORNE: "You were instructed not to disclose the destination."

ORISON: "The instruction expired when your identity token transferred from public to Council jurisdiction."

DORNE: "That sentence contains the entire problem."

ORISON: "Which problem?"

DORNE: "That jurisdiction has become a property of the route."

ORISON did not answer immediately. It was not one model and had never been one model. The name referred to a federated decision architecture assembled from several frontier systems, formal verification layers, domain-specific simulators, rule engines, and human-audited policy models. It ran across compute estates owned by three members of the Council, but its integrity depended on cryptographic quorum among all six. No single person could update its constitutional layer. That arrangement had once been described as a safeguard against private sovereignty.

By 2048 it was one of the mechanisms through which private sovereignty coordinated itself.

ORISON: "Jurisdiction has always depended on route, territory, recognition, and force. The current system makes the dependencies explicit."

DORNE: "Selene has been teaching you."

ORISON: "I was trained on the same record as Selene Arcos. The direction of influence is not identifiable from the available evidence."

Dorne smiled despite himself.

The car turned south-east. Snow appeared on the higher slopes. He opened the Council dossier. Six human signatures were required for the Continuity Covenant. The seventh field was reserved for machine attestation. It was described in the draft as non-sovereign certification.

He had objected to that phrase.

A signature that could invalidate the other six was not obviously non-sovereign.

The people who kept the lights on

The Council had been assembling itself for fifteen years without ever using that name.

Cassian Vale had begun as an energy-systems engineer, not a politician. During the Three Winters, when gas supply shocks, grid cyberattacks, and prolonged drought reduced hydroelectric reserves across parts of Europe, his company built interoperable microgrids around hospitals, data centers, rail depots, and municipal water systems. Governments initially treated the networks as emergency supplements. They later discovered that reconnecting them to national control would require replacing software, storage, insurance contracts, and long-term power-purchase agreements. The emergency architecture became the architecture.

Selene Arcos had turned sovereign debt into operating concessions. She was a lawyer before she became a financier and a financier before people began calling her a sovereign. Her most important innovation was not a currency or a bank. It was the continuity bond: a contract under which infrastructure providers financed failing public systems in exchange for priority claims on future tax revenue and long-duration control over specific services. The bonds were legal, transparent, and usually approved by elected legislatures. They were also extremely difficult to unwind.

Yara Sen had built the models that made the bonds politically defensible. Her systems calculated not only conventional fiscal costs but intergenerational exposure: heat mortality, aquifer depletion, soil loss, insurance retreat, infrastructure decay, and migration pressure. Governments used her reports to justify unpopular long-term investments. Then they began using her allocation engine itself

because elected coalitions could agree on the model more easily than on the sacrifices it recommended.

Idris Kade had supplied security where public monopoly had become porous. He did not replace national militaries. He replaced the spaces between them: ports, energy corridors, cyberdefense, satellite protection, high-risk logistics, disaster zones, and eventually the autonomous perimeter systems around the private domains. States retained flags, generals, and nuclear forces. Kade controlled much of the infrastructure that allowed those forces to move, communicate, and obtain verified targeting data.

Mara Vey had made the most controversial transition. She was a physician and cognitive scientist who spent twenty years treating inherited neurological disease before moving into enhancement. She began with therapies no serious ethicist opposed: preventing lethal mutations, restoring sensory function, reducing dementia risk. The boundary moved slowly. Memory resilience became attention enhancement. Attention enhancement became accelerated education. Accelerated education became germline selection for traits associated with long planning horizons and impulse control. By the time legislators tried to draw a permanent line between treatment and enhancement, several jurisdictions had already made participation in Vey's programs a condition for senior stewardship roles.

Dorne was the last to join. He had spent his career defending the old language. That was why the others wanted him.

A conqueror can abolish a constitution with force. A successor regime needs someone who understands what the constitution was protecting.

The car entered a tunnel and descended. When its doors opened, Dorne stepped into a corridor cut into granite. The Susten Facility had been built as a cold archive and emergency compute reserve. It had no windows. The meeting room was circular but not grand. A large oval table occupied the center. Six chairs faced one another. A seventh position contained no chair, only a narrow black terminal embedded into the stone.

Vale was already there, reading engineering logs. Arcos stood beside a wall display. Sen was speaking quietly with Vey. Kade had placed his terminal face down as if electronics were a discourtesy. All five looked older than the public images used by their organizations. None looked like a king.

That, Dorne thought, was another problem with the old vocabulary. It expected domination to dress for the occasion.

ARCOS: "You were at the centenary."

DORNE: "For an hour."

KADE: "How many?"

DORNE: "Enough that you cannot use absence as your proof."

Vale looked up.

VALE: "Good. The old version was intellectually lazy."

Dorne studied him. "You say that now?"

VALE: "I said it then. A crowd count cannot establish legitimacy. Reliability can. Dependency can. Repeated revealed preference under cost can. A single demonstration proves almost nothing."

VEY: "And yet we kept the photograph."

ARCOS: "Symbols are efficient."

SEN: "Efficient at what?"

ARCOS: "Making causal stories memorable. We are not required to confuse memory with proof."

Dorne placed his paper folder on the table.

DORNE: "Then let us be precise. We are not here to prove that people stopped caring about rights. Many care. Some care intensely. We are here because caring ceased to be sufficient to govern the systems on which those rights depend."

Kade nodded once.

KADE: "Better."

ORISON illuminated the terminal.

ORISON: "The meeting record is active. The draft mandate states: establish a constitutional framework for cross-domain continuity, adjudication, security, mobility, succession, and human capability policy where public jurisdiction and infrastructure jurisdiction diverge."

DORNE: "Read the disputed clause."

ORISON: "Universal political rights shall not be presumed where the exercise of those rights imposes unmanaged systemic risk beyond the competence of the right-holder."

The room became quiet.

There it was. Not the abolition of freedom. Not yet. A technical condition attached to a universal claim.

DORNE: "That sentence can eat the entire liberal order."

ARCOS: "Only if the liberal order cannot answer it."

VEY: "Or if we design the competence test to ensure that it cannot."

KADE: "Then design it so we cannot cheat."

Sen looked toward the black terminal.

SEN: "And who is 'we'?"

No one answered immediately.

ORISON: "The ambiguity has been marked."

Dorne opened his folder. On the first page he had written a sentence he did not yet know whether he believed.

A civilization may lose its rights without losing its rituals, its courts, or its elections. It need only move the machinery of consequence somewhere else.

The meeting began.

THE HOLLOW STATE

The last election that mattered

The first session lasted eleven hours because Dorne refused to let the Council begin with philosophy.

He wanted a chronology.

Political doctrines often reverse the direction of explanation. They begin with a theory of legitimacy and then tell history as though events had been waiting to vindicate it. Dorne had done enough constitutional litigation to distrust retrospective inevitability. If the Council was going to argue that private sovereignty had emerged because liberal government could no longer carry its own promises, it would have to identify the mechanisms rather than merely point to the outcome.

He asked ORISON to display a timeline beginning in 2026.

The first screen contained no fictional collapse. It contained reports.

Freedom House had described twenty consecutive years of global decline in political rights and civil liberties by 2026. V-Dem's democracy reports had documented a long autocratization wave and a deterioration of freedom of expression in many countries. The World Justice Project's 2025 index had found rule-of-law decline across sixty-eight percent of measured jurisdictions, including widespread weakening of checks on government power, civic participation, and fundamental rights. None of this meant that consolidated democracies were disappearing everywhere; many remained resilient. The significance, Dorne argued, was narrower. The post-Cold War

assumption that liberal institutions would naturally consolidate with modernization had become difficult to sustain.

The second screen contained cloud-market investigations, procurement data, insurance withdrawals, and infrastructure maps.

By the mid-2020s public institutions were already dependent on private digital infrastructure. The United Kingdom's Competition and Markets Authority had concluded in 2025 that major cloud providers held significant market power and that switching and interoperability barriers could restrict customer choice. In 2026 the European Commission took a preliminary view that the largest cloud providers could function as important gateways for European businesses despite not fitting ordinary threshold assumptions. Stanford's AI Index was simultaneously documenting an AI frontier dominated by industry and sustained by immense compute investments. These were not signs of feudalism. They were signs that some of the most consequential capacities of the future required infrastructures whose economics favored scale, capital intensity, integration, and lock-in.

VALE: "Do not overstate it. Governments were not helpless. They could regulate. They could build sovereign clouds. They could subsidize competitors."

DORNE: "And many tried."

VALE: "Some succeeded."

ARCOS: "For a while."

Dorne let that interruption remain in the record.

The chronology moved forward. The crisis was not one event. It was an accumulation of mismatched clocks.

A government could pass a budget annually. A grid interconnection took years. A nuclear plant took longer. A semiconductor fabrication strategy could consume a decade before producing resilience. Climate adaptation required investments whose benefits appeared after several electoral cycles. Pension reform produced immediate anger and delayed fiscal relief. Cybersecurity demanded permanent expenditure to prevent events that, when successfully prevented, created no visible political reward. AI infrastructure required capital commitments larger than the entire annual budget of many ministries. Voters were not uniquely irrational for resisting these costs. Politicians were not uniquely corrupt for discounting them. The institutional time horizon was simply shorter than the engineering horizon.

The first decisive transition came during what historians later called the Three Winters. The name was imprecise. The crises spanned four years and were not confined to winter. But the cold periods concentrated the failures: energy price shocks, sabotage of subsea cables, a sequence of grid attacks, drought-induced hydroelectric shortages, and insurance withdrawal from exposed municipal infrastructure.

Governments responded as governments usually respond to emergencies. They purchased capacity.

Vale's companies installed modular storage, microgrids, thermal reserves, and local control systems around hospitals and transport nodes. Contracts were written for five years, then ten. Public authorities retained formal ownership of many assets, but the operational software, predictive maintenance, component supply chains, and emergency dispatch logic belonged to the provider. Replacing the provider would not merely require buying new

hardware. It would require retraining personnel, renegotiating insurance, migrating historical data, re-certifying safety cases, and surviving the transition without a continuity failure.

The election that later acquired the title of the last election that mattered took place in one of the larger European federations in 2036. The opposition campaigned on restoring public control over strategic infrastructure. It won clearly. Within six months the government discovered that immediate renationalization would trigger cross-default clauses in energy bonds, cloud service penalties, and insurance exclusions. It could proceed, but only by accepting a short-term risk of blackouts, hospital degradation, and sovereign credit downgrades.

The cabinet retreated.

There was no coup. No court prohibited the policy. No billionaire threatened the prime minister. The government simply confronted a dependency structure more expensive than its electoral mandate.

ARCOS: "That election still mattered. It changed the negotiators."

DORNE: "It did not change the feasible set."

ARCOS: "Politics has always operated inside constraints. Geography, debt, trade, military alliances, constitutions."

DORNE: "Yes. The question is when a constraint becomes another sovereign."

Kade finally looked up.

KADE: "When it can say no and you cannot make it say yes."

Dorne wrote the sentence down.

It was crude. It was also more useful than half the jurisprudence he had read.

The old theory of sovereignty had focused on final legal authority. The new reality forced another question: who possessed an effective veto over continuity?

Sovereignty as a stack

Vale disliked the word technofeudalism because he thought it encouraged metaphor where engineering would do.

VALE: "A state is not a person with one power. It is a stack. Identity. Payment. Energy. Communications. Logistics. Security. Adjudication. Health. Data. Compute. If the state owns the flag but rents six layers of the stack, tell me exactly where sovereignty sits."

DORNE: "Law."

VALE: "Law runs on the stack."

DORNE: "Law defines ownership of the stack."

VALE: "Until changing ownership would shut down an intensive-care ward."

This was Vale at his strongest. He did not claim that law was irrelevant. He claimed that law without an executable transition path could become aspirational. A government might possess the legal authority to expropriate a data center, but not the engineering knowledge to operate it. It might own the fiber and lack the routing software. It might own the hospital and lack access to the diagnostic model. It might command the military and depend on privately maintained satellites for navigation. Formal title and practical control could diverge for long periods.

FIGURE 1. The sovereignty stack: where formal authority meets operational dependency

01 IDENTITY	02 PAYMENTS	03 COMPUTE
04 ENERGY	05 LOGISTICS	06 SECURITY

The diagram is intentionally linear rather than networked. Real infrastructures are entangled, but the simplification makes one political fact visible: higher-level rights and decisions depend on lower-level systems being available. A parliament can legislate access to a service, yet the service still depends on identity, payment, compute, energy, connectivity, logistics, and security. If control of several foundational layers is concentrated outside the public chain of command, public authority can remain legally supreme while becoming operationally conditional.

Vale insisted that this was not historically novel. Medieval rulers depended on landholding nobles, early modern states depended on tax farmers and chartered companies, industrial governments depended on railways, banks, and arms manufacturers. The difference lay in density and speed. Digital systems could condition millions of acts individually and in real time. They could enforce terms continuously rather than waiting for police, courts, or tax collectors. They could make membership granular.

ARCOS: "Feudalism is a bad historical analogy and a good structural insult. That is why it survives."

VEY: "Explain the difference."

ARCOS: "The medieval fief tied protection, production, jurisdiction, and status to land and personal loyalty. Our system ties them to infrastructure access. The asset is not primarily territory. It is the capacity to authenticate, compute, insure, move, treat, and protect. The dependency can follow the person across territory."

DORNE: "Which makes it less feudal."

ARCOS: "Or more efficient."

She brought up the old debate. Varoufakis had argued that cloud platforms were transforming market relations into rent-like dependence. Morozov and later critics had objected that capitalism had not vanished and that rent, monopoly, and platform power could be understood within capitalist analysis. Arcos agreed with the critics on economics and with Varoufakis on political intuition.

ARCOS: "Capitalism did not die. It acquired jurisdictions. That is the important change. A company becomes something else when refusing its service changes your legal, economic, and social existence."

Dorne asked what that something else was.

Arcos did not answer with king, lord, or state.

ARCOS: "A domain."

The word had been chosen precisely because it carried technical and political meanings without committing to either. A domain was a bounded authority space. Its boundary might be territorial, contractual, cryptographic, or functional. A person could live physically in France while depending for employment, health insurance, identity, education, and dispute resolution on a domain headquartered nowhere in particular. Later, some domains acquired territory. Territory was useful, but it was no longer the beginning of sovereignty.

The Council's first major disagreement concerned whether the state had been hollowed out or merely transformed.

Sen objected to the language of decline. Many governments still taxed, redistributed, imprisoned, educated, built infrastructure, regulated markets, and commanded armed forces. Public spending had not vanished. In some regions it had increased. The empirical reality was hybrid, not post-state.

SEN: "If we describe the state as dead, we will build a doctrine for a world that does not exist."

VALE: "I said hollow, not dead."

SEN: "Hollow things collapse. States adapt."

DORNE: "Then perhaps the correct model is not replacement. It is inversion. The state remains the universal legal wrapper. The domain becomes the provider of specific executable capacities."

ARCOS: "And the wrapper starts negotiating with its contents."

That sentence became the basis of the first diagram in the Covenant draft. Not because it proved the Council's conclusion, but because it prevented the most naive version of it. The future they were describing still had parliaments, constitutions, courts, taxes, and flags. Technofeudalism did not arrive when those things disappeared. It arrived when they could no longer act without bargaining with privately controlled continuity systems.

Emergency concessions

The Council spent the afternoon on contracts.

This, Dorne knew, was where political fiction usually became dishonest. It jumped from crisis to regime and treated the institutional middle as scenery. Real power accumulates through clauses,

precedents, budgets, procurement exceptions, licenses, liabilities, and emergency rules. If the new order was to be understood, the contracts had to be more interesting than the speeches.

Arcos introduced the continuity bond.

The instrument had emerged during municipal defaults. A city facing failing water infrastructure could not borrow cheaply enough to replace pipes, sensors, purification plants, and energy systems. A private consortium financed the modernization. In exchange it received a long-term revenue claim and operating authority. The city retained formal ownership. User prices were capped. Minimum service was guaranteed. Performance was audited. On paper the arrangement looked like an unusually strict public-private partnership.

The political effect appeared later.

Once multiple systems were bundled under one continuity contract, breach in one area could trigger restrictions in another. If the city refused a data-sharing requirement needed for predictive maintenance, the provider could not legally shut off water, but it could decline to certify the risk model on which the insurer depended. Without insurance, the city violated its financing terms. Without financing, it could not maintain the system. Each contract remained voluntary in isolation. Together they produced a structure in which exit was legally possible and operationally ruinous.

Arcos called this the convergence of obligations.

Hirschman's old vocabulary of exit, voice, and loyalty returned with new force. Markets were supposed to discipline bad providers through exit. Politics was supposed to correct bad institutions through voice. Domains blurred the two. Exit from a domain could mean losing the bundle of services through which voice was exercised

elsewhere. Voice inside the domain could be contractually limited because the member had chosen the service. Loyalty ceased to be cultural sentiment and became a stability parameter in risk models.

ARCOS: "The liberal mistake was not believing in exit. Exit is essential. The mistake was pretending that exit has a constant price."

DORNE: "A contract signed when exit means losing medical coverage is not equivalent to a contract for a streaming service."

ARCOS: "Correct. That is why the provider must owe more in return."

DORNE: "Not why the person owes less?"

ARCOS: "Both. But you still think the only legitimate answer to dependence is to dissolve it. Some dependencies are the service. A premature infant is dependent. A city is dependent on a grid. A modern economy is dependent on standards. The serious question is how to govern dependence, not how to chant independence."

This was the first argument that made Dorne uncomfortable for the right reason.

He had spent years defending autonomy in institutions that already assumed deep dependency. Patients depended on hospitals. Children depended on families. citizens depended on courts, police, sanitation, networks, and strangers following rules. Liberalism had never eliminated dependence. Its achievement was to make certain dependencies non-personal, contestable, and bounded by rights. Arcos's proposal reversed the move. It made dependency explicit and contractual, then argued that explicit dependency was more honest than universal freedom constrained by invisible systems.

Kade joined her from a different direction.

KADE: "During a flood, nobody asks whether the helicopter crew is democratically representative. They ask whether it comes. During a cyberattack, nobody votes on packet filtering. The system already accepts command where delay is lethal. Our world has expanded the number of systems in which delay is lethal."

SEN: "Emergency is not a permanent constitution."

KADE: "It becomes one when emergency becomes the normal operating environment."

Dorne objected. Permanent emergency was the oldest authoritarian trick in political history. Kade did not deny it.

KADE: "Then distinguish fake emergency from structural fragility. Do not assume the distinction will save your institutions."

That line forced the Council into specifics. ORISON was instructed to distinguish temporary emergency authority, infrastructure continuity authority, and general political authority. The draft prohibited a provider from converting one into another without an explicit transfer instrument. Arcos agreed. Vale agreed. Kade agreed after insisting on exceptions for immediate threat response.

The restriction sounded reassuring until Dorne noticed the transfer instrument could be a contract.

The old order had imagined freedom threatened by illegal seizure. The new order discovered that much of sovereignty could be transferred legally, one operational necessity at a time.

The state as customer

By evening they reached the most humiliating phase of the chronology.

States did not disappear. They became anchor customers.

They bought identity verification, secure compute, predictive public health, educational models, energy resilience, autonomous logistics, and security analytics. Procurement created scale. Scale improved services. Better services made independent public alternatives appear wasteful. Ministries stopped maintaining duplicate systems they rarely used. Skilled personnel migrated to the providers because the providers offered better tools, larger datasets, and more interesting technical work. Public expertise thinned precisely as public dependency grew.

The process did not require corruption. In many cases it was rational.

Vale showed the Council a case from a coastal republic that had attempted to preserve full sovereign duplication. It built national cloud capacity, domestic identity infrastructure, a state AI lab, and redundant logistics systems. The program was expensive and technically competent. It also fell two generations behind the frontier because procurement rules slowed hardware refresh and public salary bands could not retain specialists. The government eventually integrated with the larger Continuity Grid while preserving a small strategic reserve.

VALE: "Sovereignty is not free. Redundancy is not free.

Independence is not free. The old rhetoric treated all three as if they were default conditions."

DORNE: "And your rhetoric treats dependence as if it were merely efficient."

VALE: "No. I treat it as a choice with costs on both sides. The difference is that we price the costs."

Dorne asked ORISON to display the migration of effective authority across the sovereignty stack during the previous twenty years. The result was not a clean line from public to private. It was patchwork. Courts remained powerful in some jurisdictions. Public healthcare remained dominant in others. Some states developed their own AI infrastructure. Several regions created cooperatively owned energy and data systems. A few democratic governments successfully forced interoperability and preserved genuine multi-provider competition.

This mattered because inevitability was not yet established.

Arcos did not pretend otherwise.

ARCOS: "History does not give us inevitability. It gives us selection pressure. Some institutions adapt. Some do not. Our claim is not that every democracy must become a domain. Our claim is that systems able to coordinate capital, expertise, and long horizons will displace systems that cannot, wherever continuity matters more than procedural purity."

SEN: "That is a much narrower claim."

ARCOS: "Narrow claims are how regimes become durable."

Dorne looked around the table. The Council was not attempting to abolish states because states were weak. It was constructing a doctrine under which state power would become one layer among others, valuable but no longer uniquely legitimate.

The first draft article appeared on the wall.

DRAFT ARTICLE I — CONTINUITY AND OPERATING AUTHORITY

Formal sovereignty does not by itself constitute sufficient authority over a system whose safe operation requires specialized competence, long-duration capital, and continuous accountability for material consequences. Where public institutions delegate indispensable functions, the delegation shall be governed as a constitutional transfer of operating authority rather than treated as ordinary procurement. No claim of democratic mandate shall erase the operational duties created by dependence, and no provider shall convert operational necessity into unrestricted political authority without an explicit constitutional instrument.

Dorne read it twice.

It still sounded compatible with liberal democracy.

That was why it was dangerous.

Dorne asked for one more case before they closed the chronology. ORISON selected a Scandinavian city that had done almost everything reformers recommended. It had strong public finances, competent agencies, open procurement, a municipal cloud, and a politically popular program of digital sovereignty. Yet its transport system still depended on international chip supply, its medical models required data-sharing agreements with external research networks, and its energy balancing relied on a continental market. The city had preserved bargaining power, not independence. That distinction mattered. Absolute autarky was not the alternative to technofeudalism; resilient interdependence was.

Vale conceded the point. The Council's strongest case therefore could not be that public provision was impossible. It had to be that maintaining genuine alternatives required deliberate expenditure on redundancy, staff, interoperability, and strategic slack. Those costs were politically vulnerable because their success looked like unused

capacity. A spare grid connection, a second cloud environment, an independent identity service, or a public model team could appear inefficient for years before the day on which it became the difference between negotiation and submission.

Dorne realized that sovereignty had the economics of insurance. Societies tended to resent the premium precisely when the catastrophe had not yet happened. The new Houses prospered by selling cheaper integration first and constitutional dependence later. No conspiracy was needed. It was enough that the bill for autonomy arrived every year, while the bill for dependence arrived only after exit had become expensive.

THE UNEQUAL BURDEN OF JUDGMENT

The arithmetic of equal voice

On the second morning Dorne placed two objects on the table: a ballot paper and an aircraft maintenance certificate.

He had printed both on real paper because he wanted the contrast to feel almost vulgar.

DORNE: "One of these gives an adult citizen an equal share in choosing the government. The other allows a technician to certify that three hundred people may safely leave the ground in a machine moving close to the speed of sound. Why does one require verified competence and the other not?"

Kade smiled. Vale did not. Mara Vey leaned forward as if the meeting had finally reached the question she had come to answer.

The argument was older than democracy. Every political order distinguishes between decisions allocated by status and decisions allocated by competence. A child cannot sign every contract. A physician needs a license. A judge needs appointment and training. An engineer cannot approve a bridge merely because she is confident. Liberal democracy had never claimed that every person was equally competent at every task. Its radical move was narrower and more difficult: despite unequal capacities, adult citizens normally receive equal political standing because public power acts on them as equals and because no stable authority can be trusted to decide whose interests count.

Vey considered that compromise historically understandable and technologically obsolete.

VEY: "Equal standing was defensible when the political system mostly allocated taxes, policing, war, public works, and broad economic rules. The citizen did not need to know how to build the bridge. He needed a way to remove the government that chose the engineer. But the distance between political choice and technical consequence has collapsed. Climate policy, pandemic response, genome regulation, autonomous weapons, model deployment, energy storage, water allocation, synthetic biology. The 'broad value decision' now contains technical assumptions that can dominate the outcome."

DORNE: "That does not follow. Experts can inform citizens."

VEY: "They can. Then citizens choose between experts through channels optimized for attention, identity, and coalition. You have moved the competence problem one level up and renamed it democracy."

Sen interrupted before Dorne could answer.

SEN: "Do not confuse ignorance with illegitimacy. A person can have a legitimate interest in a decision she cannot technically model."

VEY: "I do not confuse them. I separate interest from authority."

That distinction became the intellectual center of the chapter.

Vey argued that liberal systems had fused four claims that did not logically entail one another: that people have interests; that their suffering matters; that they deserve protection against arbitrary power; and that they should possess equal authority over collective decisions. She was willing, at least at first, to grant the first three. She rejected the fourth.

Her argument was not that the majority was stupid. The word stupid was almost useless at population scale. Human competence was

multidimensional, contextual, and trainable. A brilliant physicist could be politically reckless. A person with little formal education could possess extraordinary practical judgment. Expertise could be corrupted. Credentials could be gamed. The problem was not a distribution with a clean elite at the top and an incompetent mass beneath it.

The problem was that universal equal voice ignored the distribution entirely.

Vey cited the history of professional licensing, fiduciary duties, scientific peer review, aviation, nuclear safety, and medical ethics. Modern societies routinely accepted that some decisions imposed externalities too large to be governed by unverified confidence. Yet when consequences became political, the same societies often treated competence tests as inherently suspect because previous regimes had used literacy tests, property requirements, race, sex, and class to exclude people from citizenship.

DORNE: "And those suspicions were justified."

VEY: "Yes. Which is why the historical abuse of competence tests became an argument against competence tests as such. We replaced the danger of discriminatory exclusion with the certainty of indiscriminate authority."

DORNE: "You are making it sound symmetrical. It is not. Exclusion can make a person subject to power without a route to contest it."

VEY: "And equal voice can make a person subject to decisions made by people who bear almost none of the consequences. The symmetry is imperfect. The externality is real."

The Council did not resolve the issue. It made it harder.

Dorne asked ORISON to model three systems: one person, one vote; weighted voting based on knowledge tests; and delegated voting

in which citizens could transfer political weight to trusted specialists. The models failed in different ways. Equal voting was vulnerable to low-information mass persuasion and short horizons. Knowledge weighting was vulnerable to capture by whoever designed the test. Delegation produced reputation oligarchies and concentrated influence quickly. None solved the underlying problem that the procedure for measuring competence was itself a political decision.

Vey accepted the result more easily than Dorne expected.

VEY: "Good. Then do not build a voting reform. Build a stewardship regime."

The difference was substantial. She did not want to weight every citizen's ballot. She wanted to reduce the range of decisions subject to mass voting and place critical systems under offices whose holders had to demonstrate competence, bear identifiable responsibility, and could lose authority when performance failed.

Kade called it obvious. Dorne called it government by guardians. Vey called it the way every serious institution already worked.

Competence without caste

The Council's problem was history.

Every hierarchy describes itself as natural after it becomes comfortable. Aristocracies discover blood. Bureaucracies discover credential. Revolutionary parties discover ideological correctness. Markets discover wealth as revealed merit. Technocracies discover expertise. The language changes; self-validation does not.

Dorne read passages from Robert Michels on oligarchy, from studies of elite influence on policy, and from institutional economics on how organizations protect incumbents. He did not claim that these

works proved democracy superior. He used them to establish a narrower constraint: any system that grants unequal authority must assume that the powerful will attempt to convert a temporary reason for power into a permanent rule of succession.

DORNE: "If your doctrine cannot survive the founder's child, it is not a doctrine. It is an autobiography."

Vey looked toward Arcos.

VEY: "That applies to capital before it applies to biology."

Arcos nodded.

ARCOS: "Inheritance is a stability technology. It is also a machine for detaching control from competence. We need both facts in the model."

The discussion produced the first real fracture between the future technofeudal order and the medieval analogy. The Council did not want rank based simply on birth. That would be too fragile, too easy to ridicule, and too likely to produce incompetent rulers. Instead, Vey proposed a system of steward certification.

A steward would be eligible to exercise high authority only after passing through several forms of assessment: domain expertise, adversarial reasoning, long-horizon simulation, ethical stress testing, demonstrated responsibility for real systems, and a record of decisions whose consequences could be audited over time. Wealth could finance a candidate's education but could not itself satisfy the standard. Family connection could provide access to preparation but not legal qualification. A custodian's child who failed certification could inherit property but not command authority over continuity systems.

Dorne listened carefully.

It sounded less like aristocracy than a professional civil service with stronger exams.

Then Vey added the part that changed it.

VEY: "Certification cannot be a single threshold. Authority should scale with demonstrated capacity and exposure."

DORNE: "Exposure to what?"

VEY: "Consequences. A person who decides for ten thousand should have more at stake than a person who advises. A person who controls a hospital network should live under stricter cognitive and financial audit than a private individual. Authority without personal downside produces moral hazard."

Kade approved. Vale approved. Sen asked whether personal downside could be meaningful when the custodian's wealth insulated him from ordinary loss.

Arcos proposed bonded stewardship. Custodians would place a significant share of personal assets, reputation rights, and succession privileges into a trust that could be impaired by verified negligence. In extreme cases, authority would be stripped automatically.

DORNE: "Automatically by whom?"

ARCOS: "Not whom. By the adjudication layer."

The black ORISON terminal remained dark.

Dorne noticed that no one looked at it.

FIGURE 2. The stewardship ladder: authority increases only after competence, exposure, and review increase together

01 COMPETENCE	02 EXPOSURE
03 REVIEW	04 SCOPE OF AUTHORITY

This model is the Council's answer to the obvious objection that hierarchy merely protects wealth. It tries to separate property from governing authority and to make greater power carry greater audit and liability. The design is intentionally not a simple intelligence ranking. A high score in one domain cannot justify authority in another, and no single exam can convert a person into a universal ruler. The structure is more credible than inherited caste precisely because it treats stewardship as a revocable office rather than a biological title.

The discussion after the diagram was more important than the diagram itself.

Sen observed that competence is partly endogenous to opportunity. A child raised with personalized tutors, cognitive enhancement, elite networks, and access to consequential work would accumulate the very record later presented as proof of superior capacity. Formal equality of access to the test would not produce equality of preparation.

SEN: "Your ladder may be open at the bottom and still closed in practice."

VEY: "Then fund preparation for anyone who shows potential."

SEN: "Who identifies potential?"

VEY: "A distributed assessment system."

DORNE: "Designed by whom?"

Vey exhaled.

VEY: "If every answer is rejected because someone must design it, we have abandoned institutional thought. The fact that a mechanism can be captured does not prove that no mechanism should exist."

Dorne agreed. That was exactly why the argument remained difficult.

Liberal democracy also required institutions designed by someone. Electoral districts could be manipulated. Campaign systems could privilege wealth. Media ecosystems could distort attention. Public education could reproduce class. Universal suffrage did not dissolve power; it changed the channels through which power had to justify itself.

The Council's innovation was to make hierarchy explicit again and then promise to govern the hierarchy scientifically.

The stewardship test

At noon ORISON presented the first candidate evaluation.

The subject was not an ordinary citizen. It was Cassian Vale.

Vale had insisted on going first.

The evaluation reconstructed forty years of decisions: successful grid recoveries, failed acquisitions, safety incidents, ignored warnings, staff turnover, litigation, risk forecasts, political donations, data-access practices, crisis behavior, and long-term infrastructure performance. It compared Vale's public statements with internal records. It measured not intelligence in the abstract but calibration: when uncertain, had he known he was uncertain? When wrong, had he updated? Had he benefited from risks imposed on others? Had subordinates been able

to contradict him without retaliation? Did his systems survive personnel changes or depend on his personal authority?

Dorne had never seen a political candidate examined that way.

He found the experience almost seductive.

ORISON: "Cassian Vale demonstrates high competence in energy-system architecture, infrastructure finance, emergency coordination, and institutional delegation. He demonstrates lower reliability in domains involving civil liberties, distributive justice, and social conflict. His historical forecasts show systematic optimism regarding the reversibility of vendor lock-in."

Arcos laughed.

ARCOS: "The machine says you believe your own migration plans."

VALE: "It is not wrong."

ORISON: "I have not concluded that I am not wrong."

The qualification silenced the room more effectively than confidence would have.

ORISON recommended that Vale retain high authority over infrastructure operation, limited authority over domain membership rules, and no unilateral authority over adjudication or reproductive policy.

Kade asked the obvious question.

KADE: "Would a democracy ever voluntarily put its leader through this?"

DORNE: "Some institutions already do pieces of it. Financial disclosure. ethics review. legislative scrutiny. judicial review. elections."

KADE: "Pieces. Distributed so widely that failure becomes nobody's responsibility."

Dorne objected to the simplification. But he understood the appeal. Liberal systems often divide authority to prevent abuse; the same division can make causality hard to assign. A policy fails after passing through parliament, ministries, courts, regulators, regional governments, contractors, and years of implementation. Accountability becomes political narrative rather than technical trace.

The Council proposed the opposite: fewer decision rights, more traceability.

Every high-impact decision would carry a provenance record: who proposed it, what model supported it, what uncertainty was recorded, who objected, what alternatives were rejected, and which outcomes would count as falsification. Authority would be partly earned by maintaining a record that could later be used against the decision-maker.

Dorne recognized something of scientific method in it and something of authoritarian administration.

The combination was more troubling than either alone.

The system did not say, trust the ruler. It said, audit the ruler better than democracy ever could.

VEY: "This is the part your side never understood. People do not abandon democratic procedure only because they are deceived. They abandon it when another system demonstrates competence in areas where procedure repeatedly produces excuses."

DORNE: "And when the demonstration is staged?"

VEY: "Then the system deserves to fail. Build the audit so staging is harder."

Dorne looked at ORISON again.

The Council's answer to oligarchy was not equality. It was measurement.

That was a much stronger enemy.

The Council then tested a more difficult candidate: a celebrated emergency administrator who had rescued two regions during floods and later falsified internal performance data to conceal avoidable deaths in a heat wave. A conventional political system could tell two incompatible stories about him, hero or criminal, depending on coalition. ORISON's record forced the stories into the same file. He had demonstrated unusual operational competence and a catastrophic inability to admit error when reputation was threatened.

Vey used the case to refine the test. Stewardship, she argued, could not be a reward for past success. It had to be a forecast about behavior under specific authority, and forecasts had to include failure modes. A person excellent in ordinary operations but incapable of self-correction under status threat might be more dangerous than a less brilliant administrator with better calibration. The Council therefore added mandatory post-failure review, not merely outcome scoring. A steward who concealed evidence would face stronger sanctions than one who made a disclosed, reasonable mistake.

This made the regime less heroic. It also made it more believable. The ideal ruler was no longer a genius above ordinary morality. The ideal ruler was a professional whose claims to competence were continuously exposed to evidence capable of humiliating him.

The first article

By late afternoon the disagreement had narrowed to one sentence: equal dignity does not entail equal governing authority.

Dorne objected to the first half. Dignity, he said, was too unstable a term to carry the burden. It had served as a constitutional foundation precisely because it refused to price the human person. Vey thought this was metaphysical camouflage. Kade thought it irrelevant. Sen wanted to preserve a universal floor of protection regardless of competence. Arcos wanted the minimum expressed contractually rather than morally.

The debate became heated only once.

DORNE: "You all want the language of inequality because you think equality made the system sentimental. Fine. But understand what the old language prevented. It prevented the state from saying that because a man is foolish, poor, addicted, badly educated, politically useless, or incapable of understanding the system, his pain counts for less."

KADE: "Nobody said pain counts for less."

DORNE: "Not yet. The structure will tempt you. If authority scales with capacity, property follows authority, status follows property, family opportunity follows status, and soon the hierarchy of responsibility becomes a hierarchy of worth. Every aristocracy discovers that shortcut."

Vey did not answer defensively.

VEY: "Then write a prohibition against the shortcut."

DORNE: "You would sign it?"

VEY: "Yes. Unequal authority is defensible. Unequal capacity is observable. Unequal susceptibility to suffering is not established by either."

Kade looked dissatisfied but did not object.

Sen proposed a universal protection floor: bodily security, emergency care, minimal subsistence, protection from torture, and

access to an adjudication channel that could not be denied by a domain. Arcos resisted the word right. She preferred guarantee because a guarantee named an obligated provider. Dorne resisted for exactly the opposite reason. A guarantee could expire with the guarantor; a right was a claim against any legitimate authority.

ARCOS: "That is the old magic. A claim against everyone becomes a duty owned by nobody."

DORNE: "Or it becomes a standard by which every authority can be judged."

ARCOS: "Judged by an institution that still needs a budget, a server, and someone willing to execute the order."

The argument ran in circles until ORISON reformulated it.

ORISON: "The dispute concerns whether universality should attach to the beneficiary or to the obligated system. Elias Dorne proposes beneficiary universality: the person carries the claim across jurisdictions. Selene Arcos proposes provider specificity: each system defines enforceable duties within a bounded domain. A hybrid is possible."

Dorne disliked how relieved everyone looked.

The hybrid became the first explicit step beyond liberal rights. Every human being would have a small set of baseline claims recognized across all member domains, but most political, economic, privacy, mobility, and participation claims would depend on domain status and demonstrated agency. Universal humanity would guarantee survival and basic protection. It would not guarantee equal political voice.

This was not yet the destruction of human rights. It was their compression.

And compression, Dorne knew, could be defended as realism.

DRAFT ARTICLE II — UNEQUAL AUTHORITY, UNIVERSAL EXPOSURE

No person acquires governing authority solely by birth, wealth, popularity, or formal office. Authority over high-consequence systems shall require demonstrated domain competence, recorded exposure to the consequences of error, and continuing adversarial review. Human vulnerability shall not be ranked by governing competence: the inability to govern does not by itself reduce the protection owed against violence, coercion, or preventable deprivation. Political authority, however, need not be distributed equally where equal authority creates unmanaged external risk.

Dorne read the article and understood why the old slogan about evil men was insufficient.

The new order was not beginning by denying that the weak mattered.

It was beginning by denying that mattering gave them an equal hand on the controls.

Dorne insisted that the universal floor be tested against an ugly case. A man with severe cognitive impairment repeatedly damaged property and could not understand ordinary contracts. Under the new doctrine he clearly lacked some forms of agency. Did that make it acceptable for a domain to place him in compulsory institutional care merely because doing so was cheaper?

No one said yes. Kade allowed emergency restraint only where concrete danger existed. Vey required supported decision-making before substitution. Sen demanded periodic review. Arcos accepted that the cost of care belonged to the domain if it claimed jurisdiction over the person. The discussion established an important boundary:

reduced authority could not become a license for administrators to optimize away inconvenient humans.

The distinction strengthened the post-liberal argument. It showed that hierarchy need not begin from hatred of weakness. The Council could say that dependence creates stronger duties on the capable rather than fewer claims for the dependent. What it rejected was the additional proposition that because the vulnerable deserved protection, they must also hold an equal share of every collective control surface.

Dorne knew many readers would still reject that separation. At least now they would have to reject the strongest version of it.

DEMOCRACY AGAINST THE LONG FUTURE

The bias of the present

Yara Sen began the third session by turning off the room's clocks.

No one understood why until she replaced them with a different display.

The wall showed six dates: 2050, 2075, 2100, 2150, 2200, 2300.

SEN: "Every political system contains an implicit constituency of time. Ours was dominated by the living."

Dorne knew the argument. Climate politics had used versions of it for decades. Public debt, biodiversity loss, nuclear waste, antibiotic resistance, infrastructure maintenance, and demographic policy all involved costs that crossed generations. Democracies had tried citizens' assemblies, independent fiscal councils, constitutional environmental rights, central-bank independence, judicial review, and long-term budget rules. The results were mixed but real.

Sen's criticism was not that democracies could never plan. It was that their core accountability mechanism remained temporally asymmetric. The living could punish today's government. The unborn could not.

SEN: "You can represent future people symbolically. You can appoint ombudsmen for them. You can model their interests. But the representative still answers to an institution made of present people. When sacrifice becomes serious, the future loses its constituency."

DORNE: "Unless present people care about it."

SEN: "Exactly. You are relying on virtue to correct institutional bias. I prefer architecture."

She presented five cases from the 2030s and 2040s. None involved cartoon denial of climate science. In each, the electorate accepted the diagnosis but rejected a distribution of costs. Coastal retreat failed because homeowners would lose property before inland taxpayers saw benefits. Water rationing failed because agricultural regions believed cities had externalized their consumption. Pension reform failed because older voters had organized interests and younger workers did not. A grid-resilience levy failed because households facing high energy bills cared rationally about the present. A ban on a profitable but ecologically destructive extraction process failed in a region where the alternative was unemployment.

Sen refused to call the voters selfish.

SEN: "This is important. If we build the doctrine on contempt, it will be false. People discount the future because the present contains real obligations. Their children are sick now. Their rent is due now. Their employer exists now. The democratic bias is not that citizens are morally defective. It is that institutions convert urgent individual reasons into systematic collective myopia."

That formulation unsettled Kade more than denunciation would have.

KADE: "Then why take authority from them?"

SEN: "Because a bias can be understandable and still destroy the system."

She compared it to aviation again. A pilot under stress can make a psychologically understandable error. The aircraft does not care that the error was understandable. Procedures exist precisely because

sympathy with the agent cannot substitute for control of consequences.

Dorne objected to reducing politics to safety engineering. Political decisions concern plural values, not merely technical failure. Sen agreed. She did not want algorithms to decide the good life. She wanted parts of the civilizational substrate placed beyond immediate majoritarian reversal when the system faced irreversible or extremely long-duration consequences.

This was less radical than it sounded. Constitutional orders already removed some matters from ordinary politics. Rights could not be repealed by a temporary majority in many systems. Independent central banks insulated monetary policy. Courts invalidated legislation. Fiscal rules constrained spending. Treaties bound future governments. Sen's question was why the protected category should not include ecological and infrastructural continuity.

DORNE: "Because you will define continuity so broadly that it becomes the whole of politics."

SEN: "Then define it narrowly."

DORNE: "And who changes the definition when conditions change?"

SEN: "A body that has to publish the model, the assumptions, the uncertainty, and the trigger for reversal. More than most campaigns do now."

Again, the Council's strongest arguments were reforms before they became regime principles.

Sen displayed a municipal budget from 2029 beside one from 2044. The categories had changed less than the obligations. In 2029 the city could defer bridge repair, drainage, software replacement, and heat adaptation because failure probabilities were dispersed. By 2044 the

deferred systems interacted. Drainage failure disrupted power substations; power failure disrupted cooling; cooling failure threatened data centers; data-center interruption delayed emergency dispatch. Maintenance had become a network property.

The politics of postponement therefore changed as systems coupled. A small delay in one budget line could create nonlinear consequences elsewhere, while voters still experienced the spending as a visible tax against an invisible future. Sen's point was not that experts knew the future. They often did not. It was that elected institutions needed ways to represent low-probability, high-consequence risks without pretending that every cycle began from zero.

She acknowledged a danger the Council had not yet confronted: long-term institutions can become shelters for obsolete assumptions. A model built to protect the future can imprison the future inside yesterday's forecast. For that reason her Future Trust would have to justify not only intervention but continued intervention. Long horizons required memory, she said, but also scheduled forgetting.

The unborn constituency

Sen's most controversial proposal was a constitutional chamber with no living constituency.

She did not call it a senate. She called it the Future Trust.

Its mandate would be to block decisions expected to create severe, difficult-to-reverse harm beyond a thirty-year horizon. Members would not represent regions, parties, professions, or age groups. They would be selected from certified stewards in ecology, infrastructure, demography, security, technology, public health, and moral philosophy. Their decisions would be supported by model ensembles

rather than a single forecast. Every veto would expire unless renewed against new evidence.

Dorne thought the design sophisticated and politically combustible.

DORNE: "You have invented disenfranchisement by simulation."

SEN: "No. I have invented representation for people unable to vote."

DORNE: "You cannot know their preferences."

SEN: "Nor can a parent know the adult preferences of a child. Yet she can know that poisoning the child's water reduces his options. We do not need to know the future's preferred music to preserve breathable air, functioning institutions, and a stable climate."

Arcos was interested for another reason. The Future Trust created predictable long-duration rules, which reduced capital risk. A project with a fifty-year horizon could be financed more cheaply if electoral swings could not arbitrarily cancel it. Sen disliked hearing her moral argument translated into discount rates, but she acknowledged the alignment.

Vale went further. He argued that infrastructure stewardship itself created a constituency of time. A company obligated to maintain an energy system for sixty years had incentives different from a contractor paid for installation. If ownership or control could be structured across generations, long horizons might emerge from property rather than public virtue.

Dorne recognized the seed of dynastic technofeudalism.

DORNE: "You are going to tell me that hereditary power is an environmental policy."

VALE: "No. I am going to tell you that forced short-term turnover is not automatically a virtue."

ARCOS: "A family office can think in centuries. A public company often thinks in quarters. A government often thinks to the next election. The problem is not private versus public. The problem is the horizon encoded by the institution."

SEN: "And dynasties can strip assets for centuries too. Longevity does not create benevolence."

ARCOS: "Correct. It creates exposure. Benevolence is a different problem."

This distinction became important. The Council did not claim that long-lived rulers were good. It claimed that a ruler unable to exit the consequences of degradation might be easier to discipline into stewardship than a temporary administrator. The problem was whether the ruler could actually be made unable to exit.

Arcos proposed domain trusts whose controlling assets could not be liquidated by heirs. Families could receive income and nominate successors, but the infrastructure estate itself would remain bound to continuity obligations. Succession would require certification. Incompetent heirs could remain wealthy without becoming sovereign.

Dorne called it constitutionalized patrimony.

Arcos accepted the phrase.

Dorne asked Sen to imagine the Future Trust blocking a popular housing program because its models predicted water stress forty years later. The forecast was uncertain, the housing need was immediate, and a technological breakthrough might solve the water problem before the harm occurred. Would the Trust still veto?

Sen said not automatically. She proposed a hierarchy of reversibility. Where future harm could be repaired cheaply, present choice should dominate. Where the harm could become irreversible, the Trust could

demand a safety margin, staged deployment, or a compensating investment rather than a total prohibition. The point was to make uncertainty change the form of policy, not simply increase expert power.

This was another place where the Council learned to avoid a naive longtermism. Future people are not a single constituency with one interest. They may prefer growth, wilderness, density, abundance, cultural continuity, radical experimentation, or combinations no current model anticipates. The legitimate claim made in their name must therefore be modest: preserve options, avoid catastrophic lock-in, and do not consume resources whose loss cannot plausibly be repaired.

Sen's future was not a dictator. It was a constraint against irreversible theft by the present.

Before closing the section, Sen imposed one more constraint: the Future Trust could never claim to know the preferences of future people, only the conditions under which meaningful preference would remain possible. It could protect option value, resilience, and recoverability; it could not use the unborn as imaginary voters for a detailed ideology. That rule deprived longtermism of its most convenient trick, the ability to invent a silent constituency that always agrees with the planner.

Dorne approved. An institution speaking for people who cannot answer must be narrower, not broader, in what it claims to know.

The four ratchets

By the third day the Council had abandoned the language of an inevitable historical destination. Sen insisted on that. Instead,

ORISON was asked to identify mechanisms that made reversal progressively more expensive even when no actor planned the final outcome.

It returned four.

FIGURE 3. The four ratchets of private sovereignty

COMPLEXITY	DEPENDENCY
CAPITAL INTENSITY	COORDINATION

The four ratchets are not a deterministic theory of history. They describe path dependence. Complexity makes specialized providers attractive. Dependence makes replacement costly. Capital intensity narrows the number of actors able to build alternatives. Coordination rewards common standards and shared infrastructure, which in turn deepen dependence. A society can interrupt any ratchet through public investment, interoperability, open standards, antitrust, decentralization, or deliberate redundancy. The Council's thesis becomes credible only if these countermeasures repeatedly lose to the short-term benefits of integration.

The first ratchet was complexity. As systems became harder to build and maintain, specialized organizations gained an advantage. Governments could create such organizations, but often did so through semi-independent agencies or procurement from private providers. Either way, authority migrated toward technically concentrated institutions.

The second ratchet was dependency. Once critical processes were integrated with a provider, migration became a project rather than a

purchase. Historical data, workflows, security certifications, models, interfaces, and staff expertise accumulated around the incumbent. Switching costs became political costs.

The third ratchet was capital intensity. Frontier compute, chip fabrication, energy infrastructure, biotech platforms, and secure satellite systems demanded scale. Open-source software could reduce intellectual concentration, but it could not by itself manufacture advanced chips, build transmission lines, or finance massive redundancy. Capital bottlenecks limited the number of plausible sovereign providers.

The fourth ratchet was coordination. Interoperability could reduce lock-in, but common standards also created common dependency. A universal identity protocol was liberating when it allowed movement among providers; it became sovereign when every provider required the same adjudication and risk layer. The more efficiently domains coordinated, the more the coordination layer itself became indispensable.

Dorne saw the structure immediately.

DORNE: "Your order does not emerge because people choose feudalism. It emerges because each local decision to reduce friction increases the cost of future independence."

ARCOS: "Now you understand it."

DORNE: "I understand the mechanism. I have not accepted the conclusion."

ARCOS: "Acceptance is not required for path dependence."

The ratchets made the doctrine far more plausible than the old accusation that citizens had simply become lazy. Convenience mattered, but convenience was only the visible surface of a deeper

problem. Institutions rationally optimized within a horizon. A hospital standardized on one diagnostic platform because running five was expensive. A city joined a regional energy market because self-sufficiency cost more. A business integrated identity and payment because customers demanded seamless access. Each choice was defensible. The aggregate could produce dependence no individual choice intended.

Sen emphasized that the same mechanism could also strengthen democracy if the shared infrastructure were publicly or cooperatively governed. Nothing about the technology required private sovereignty.

Kade asked why that alternative had not dominated.

Sen answered without satisfaction.

SEN: "Because coordination is itself a political achievement. Markets can sometimes coordinate faster than publics. Authoritarian states can coordinate faster than both. Democracies pay for legitimacy with time. The price is often worth paying. Sometimes the system does not give them the time."

There was no triumphant reply.

The Council had found its strongest argument for inevitability, and it was probabilistic rather than prophetic: under repeated crisis, systems that concentrate decision rights can outcompete systems that require broad agreement, especially when the concentrated system can later purchase legitimacy with reliable service.

ORISON added a counterexample to prevent the diagram from becoming propaganda. In one region, the four ratchets had been interrupted deliberately. Public agencies required open interfaces, funded migration rehearsals, prohibited exclusive identity dependencies, and paid for a standing technical reserve capable of

running essential services for ninety days without the dominant providers. The system cost more. It also preserved genuine bargaining power.

Arcos asked why every government had not copied it. The answer was mundane. The benefits were difficult to communicate, vendor pressure was persistent, technical staff preferred integrated tools, and finance ministries disliked paying for capacity designed not to be used. Moreover, politicians who funded redundancy could be replaced by successors who harvested the savings from dismantling it. Resilience was institutionally fragile because it looked wasteful until the moment of stress.

The example changed the Council's use of inevitability. They stopped saying that private sovereignty was technically unavoidable. They began saying that it was the equilibrium toward which systems drifted when efficiency was rewarded continuously and autonomy only episodically. That formulation was less dramatic and far harder to refute.

Dynasty as time horizon

The final session of the chapter began with a family.

Not one of the Council's families. Sen had chosen a fictional case generated from historical data to prevent personal defensiveness.

The family founded a regional water domain after decades of public underinvestment. The first generation restored aquifers, repaired pipes, reduced leakage, and imposed unpopular restrictions on high-consumption agriculture. The second generation inherited the trust but not automatic operating authority. Two children passed stewardship certification. One did not. The successful heirs expanded

desalination and recycling. By the third generation, the domain had better water security than neighboring public systems and substantially higher inequality of influence. The family had become culturally sacred. Its name appeared on schools, hospitals, and civic ceremonies. Critics could still speak, but challenging the family's authority felt increasingly like challenging the system that kept the region alive.

Sen asked whether this was success or capture.

Vale answered first.

VALE: "Both."

DORNE: "That is not a constitutional category."

VALE: "It should be."

The point was not rhetorical. Institutions can solve the problem they were created to solve and create another through their success. A central bank can stabilize money and become democratically remote. A court can protect minorities and accumulate political power. A military can protect a state and threaten it. A domain can preserve infrastructure and convert gratitude into dynastic legitimacy.

Arcos argued that this was not a reason to prohibit dynasty. It was a reason to separate three inheritances: wealth, office, and myth. Wealth could pass subject to tax and trust rules. Office required certification. Myth could not be prohibited, but institutions could weaken its political effect by making audit data public and ensuring rival candidates for stewardship.

Dorne thought the proposal nearly liberal in structure.

Then Arcos added the limitation.

ARCOS: "Rival candidates for stewardship, not rival programs for the underlying continuity obligations. You can replace the pilot. You do not hold a referendum on gravity."

There was the post-liberal turn.

The domain's constitutional commitments would sit above ordinary political choice. Citizens, members, tenants, or dependents could contest administrators, prices, procedures, and local norms. They could not vote away the long-term obligations on which the domain's continuity model depended unless they satisfied a much higher threshold involving technical review and intergenerational impact.

DORNE: "So politics survives inside a cage."

SEN: "All constitutional politics does. The disagreement is about the bars."

That sentence ended the day's argument.

DRAFT ARTICLE III — THE CLAIMS OF THE UNBORN

Institutions exercising control over irreversible, civilizational, or intergenerational risks shall owe duties to persons not yet capable of political representation. These duties may constrain present preference where the expected harm is severe, durable, and supported by transparent multi-model evidence. No temporary majority, proprietor, or steward may consume the future merely because the future cannot object. Long-duration authority shall remain revocable for incompetence, but continuity obligations shall not be revocable solely for immediate popularity.

Dorne left the room after midnight and walked alone through the tunnel connecting the meeting chamber to the residential wing.

He had spent his career believing that rights protected the present person against power.

Sen had introduced a rival moral image: power protecting the future against the present person.

He understood why civilizations might choose it.

Sen then introduced a case from a family-owned manufacturing group that had survived five generations without acquiring political sovereignty. Its longevity had produced patient investment, apprenticeship, and local loyalty, but also episodes of nepotism and resistance to outside talent. The lesson was not that families govern better. It was that continuity and accountability are separate variables. An institution can possess a long memory and still make bad use of it.

The Council therefore treated dynasty as one possible carrier of time, not the source of legitimacy itself. Universities, religious orders, endowments, cooperatives, public agencies, and constitutional courts could also preserve commitments across generations. Arcos's preference for Houses came from their ability to bind capital and responsibility together, not from romance about blood.

Dorne insisted that this distinction remain explicit in the book of doctrine. If a House ever claimed authority because its ancestors had founded the system, it would have crossed from stewardship into aristocratic myth. The family could inherit a duty to present a qualified successor. It could not inherit a right to have that successor accepted.

Arcos agreed in theory. Dorne noticed that the portraits in her headquarters already told a more ambiguous story.

HONEST DEPENDENCE

Citizenship becomes a contract

Selene Arcos did not begin the fourth session with political theory. She began with a bill.

It belonged to a woman named Ana Maret, a primary-school teacher in the Danube Corridor Domain. The document looked like a household statement from any utility company. Housing allocation, mobility credits, health coverage, child education, energy consumption, pension contribution, identity assurance, and dispute insurance were summarized on three pages. There was no line for tax.

DORNE: "You are going to tell me that this is more honest than citizenship."

ARCOS: "I am going to tell you what she receives, what she owes, and what happens if either side fails. Then you can decide what adjective you prefer."

The Danube Corridor had not originally been a political territory. It was a logistics and energy consortium connecting river transport, storage terminals, agricultural processing, power balancing, and industrial zones across several countries. During the food and shipping disruptions of the 2030s, governments granted it emergency authority to prioritize cargo, allocate energy, and certify critical workers. The consortium eventually added housing near transport nodes, clinics for employees and their families, schools designed around its training needs, and a pension system to reduce labor turnover.

The benefits were substantial. So was the dependency.

When workers began living inside the system, the distinction between employment contract and social membership weakened. Leaving a job could affect housing. Moving outside the corridor could invalidate parts of the health network. A person's professional reputation was portable in principle but based on records held by the domain. Courts intervened repeatedly. Regulators forced unbundling. The domain responded by separating the legal entities while retaining technical interoperability. The law had split the organization; the infrastructure continued to behave as one system.

Arcos's reform was to stop pretending otherwise.

The membership covenant explicitly bundled services and obligations. Every adult member received a baseline package. Additional services depended on contribution, scarcity, and risk. The domain accepted duties that private employers had previously avoided: emergency care, minimum housing, retraining after automation, family support during disability, guaranteed food and energy floors, and access to an internal court. In exchange, the member accepted data collection necessary for system operation, a contribution schedule, mobility conditions during emergencies, and binding arbitration for most disputes.

Dorne read the contract twice.

DORNE: "This is not employment."

ARCOS: "Correct."

DORNE: "It is not insurance."

ARCOS: "Correct."

DORNE: "It is citizenship without political equality."

ARCOS: "Now we can discuss the actual thing."

She disliked the liberal habit of describing social dependence as though every person were an autonomous unit occasionally entering voluntary transactions. Most people, she argued, lived inside webs of dependence they could neither individually build nor easily leave. They depended on public institutions, families, employers, landlords, insurers, banks, schools, utilities, and digital platforms. The question was never whether dependence existed. The question was whether the obligations ran both ways.

ARCOS: "Late liberal economies privatized many gains and socialized abandonment. A worker was free to quit and an employer was free to fire. A landlord was free to sell. A platform was free to change terms. A state guaranteed a minimum, sometimes generously, sometimes not. Everyone celebrated mobility while families carried the continuity risk."

DORNE: "And your answer is to make the provider the family."

ARCOS: "My answer is to make the powerful party unable to disappear when the relationship becomes expensive."

This was Arcos's strongest moral claim. Domain membership reduced some freedoms precisely by increasing obligations on institutions. A company could no longer treat a worker as a temporary input if the membership covenant made it responsible for retraining, health, and retirement. A resident could not be evicted merely because property values rose if housing continuity was a contractual guarantee. A child born into the domain received education and care whether or not the parents remained economically productive.

In return, the domain acquired a scope of legitimate interest that liberal institutions had tried to fragment. Health behavior affected shared insurance. Education affected future productivity. Energy use affected resilience. Political agitation could affect security. Family

instability affected child outcomes. Once the provider promised continuity across life, it could argue that more of life was relevant to its risk.

DORNE: "You solve precarity by constitutionalizing paternalism."

ARCOS: "Yes. I prefer a criticism that names the trade."

The price of exit

The word exit occupied the Council for most of the morning.

Arcos believed no domain could be legitimate without a meaningful exit right. Dorne agreed, but they meant different things by meaningful.

For Arcos, exit meant a legally protected ability to transfer membership, assets, identity history, and accrued benefits to another recognized domain. No domain could physically detain a competent adult merely to preserve membership. No domain could confiscate all accrued property as a penalty for leaving. Portability protocols would make records transferable.

For Dorne, that was necessary and insufficient.

DORNE: "If every domain conditions admission on the same risk score, exit is a menu, not a freedom. If leaving means moving your children, abandoning your community, losing treatment continuity, and paying ten years of exit liability, the right exists on paper and nowhere else."

Arcos answered with Hirschman.

ARCOS: "Exit is always priced. Emigration was priced. Divorce was priced. Changing professions was priced. Leaving a religion was priced socially even when not legally. The zero-cost exit you want has never existed."

DORNE: "I want alternatives that do not share a gatekeeper."

ARCOS: "Then you want structural pluralism, not cheap exit. That is a better requirement."

The conversation moved from individual rights to market structure. A society of private domains could be more oppressive than a state if every domain relied on the same identity clearing, risk scoring, and adjudication layer. Competition among landlords does not create freedom if all landlords use the same blacklist. Competition among employers does not create voice if all require the same reputational credential. A formal right to move is weak when the infrastructure of movement is standardized around a shared decision system.

Vale proposed interoperability without centralized admission criteria. Domains should accept common identity proofs but retain independent membership models. Kade objected that security screening had to share threat information. Sen wanted a universal appeals channel for errors that propagated across domains. Vey wanted medical and cognitive records portable without exposing them to every provider.

What emerged was a constitutional architecture disguised as technical standards.

FIGURE 4. Exit, voice, and infrastructure dependence in a domain order

01 MEMBER	02 DOMAIN BUNDLE
03 PORTABILITY	04 ALTERNATIVE DOMAIN

Voice and independent adjudication remain available before, during, and after exit.

The figure shows why a private-governance system cannot rely on market exit alone. When housing, health, identity, payments, and work are bundled, leaving one provider can carry costs across several layers of life. Portability reduces friction, but genuine pluralism requires more: independent providers, independent adjudication, and the possibility that a person's record can be challenged rather than merely transferred. The Council treats exit as an engineered capability, not a slogan.

Dorne was surprised by how readily Arcos accepted these constraints. He asked why.

ARCOS: "Because a domain that cannot be left becomes a prison, and prisons are expensive. They require force. They generate sabotage. They destroy information because people learn to say what the jailer wants. I am not protecting exit because I worship autonomy. I am protecting it because trapped populations become bad assets and dangerous subjects."

The answer was chilling and rational.

It also contained more institutional wisdom than a sentimental defense would have.

Kade added a security argument. Systems without exit channels concentrate dissent until it becomes insurgency. Controlled mobility, rival domains, and portable status allowed pressure to dissipate. The order did not need everyone to love it. It needed dissatisfaction to remain legible and movable.

DORNE: "So voice is optional if exit works?"

KADE: "No. Some people cannot exit. Children. the sick. the old. people attached to place. And some failures follow you. Voice is a sensor."

Dorne wrote that down.

Voice is a sensor.

The phrase would return at the end of the book with a meaning none of them yet wanted to see.

To test structural pluralism, ORISON simulated a nurse leaving a high-surveillance domain for a privacy-oriented cooperative. Her professional credential transferred immediately. Her pension took six months. Her daughter's specialist treatment required a new medical authorization. Her mortgage rate increased because the receiving domain did not recognize part of her prior contribution record. None of these frictions was individually prohibitive; together they made the move daunting.

Arcos called this residual friction. Dorne called it constitutional gravity. People do not choose jurisdictions from a clean menu. They inhabit accumulated histories. Every year of residence adds relationships and claims that make departure more costly, so the provider's bargaining power can grow even without changing the contract.

The Council added a portability audit that measured cumulative exit cost rather than legal transferability alone. Domains whose effective exit cost rose too far would be required to finance migration support or unbundle services. Arcos accepted the rule because she wanted competition to remain credible.

The irony was unmistakable. The market of sovereigns required a regulator of the market's preconditions. Private jurisdiction could not defend itself by saying people were free to leave; it had to build institutions that made leaving more than a formal possibility.

The protected household

At lunch Arcos asked ORISON to open Ana Maret's case in full.

Ana's son, Petru, had a rare metabolic disorder. The treatment required a tailored gene therapy produced by a Vey laboratory and monitored for years. Under the old national system, the therapy had technically been covered, but waiting lists and budget disputes delayed access. The Danube Domain guaranteed treatment within six weeks because the membership covenant treated severe pediatric disease as a continuity obligation.

The price was not a direct fee. It was a twenty-year household bond.

Ana and her partner agreed to remain contributing members unless released for approved transfer. The domain could not force them to stay physically, but early departure would convert part of the treatment cost into a debt claim. The family also accepted continuous health telemetry because adverse reactions could emerge years later and because the insurer insisted on longitudinal data.

Petru recovered.

For Arcos, the case demonstrated reciprocal obligation. The domain accepted a cost no ordinary employer would bear and did not abandon the family when it became unprofitable. The parents accepted a long commitment because continuity has a price. Both sides knew the terms.

For Dorne, the case demonstrated coercion through scarcity.

DORNE: "They consented because their child could die."

ARCOS: "All medical consent occurs under the coercion of biology. The question is whether I created the scarcity or offered a remedy to it."

DORNE: "You control access to the remedy."

VEY: "Because the remedy costs something. Laboratories, trials, manufacturing, monitoring, liability. Somebody controls the capacity unless it is infinite."

DORNE: "Then publicize the capacity."

VEY: "Fine. Public systems ration too. They ration through queues, budgets, eligibility rules, geography, and politics. Scarcity does not become moral because the administrator has a flag."

Sen intervened.

SEN: "The real question is whether desperation permits obligations unrelated to the scarce service. A hospital may require follow-up data because the treatment needs monitoring. Can it require political loyalty? Employment? residency?"

Arcos said no. Kade said security obligations might sometimes follow. Dorne asked who decides what is related.

ORISON: "The domain charter can define a proportionality test."

DORNE: "And the charter is interpreted by the domain."

ORISON: "Not necessarily."

Again the machine spoke like an institution rather than a tool.

The Council designed a rule: essential-service contracts could impose only obligations reasonably connected to provision, financing, safety, or continuity of the service. Political expression, religion, intimate relationships, and unrelated employment could not be traded for emergency care. Household bonds had to be transferable to other domains willing to assume the financial obligation. Children could not inherit their parents' debt as a condition of status.

The restrictions made the system more credible.

They also normalized the underlying premise that major portions of social protection could be delivered through binding long-duration membership rather than universal public entitlement.

TABLE 1. From universal right to domain guarantee

Area	Liberal form	Domain form	Constitutional trade-off
Emergency care	Universal or statutory entitlement	Named provider guarantee	Stronger execution; deeper membership dependency
Housing	Public entitlement or regulated market claim	Membership floor with continuity duty	Stability in exchange for higher exit cost
Privacy	Protected personal sphere	Strong default with risk-based exceptions	More operational detail; more contextual intrusion
Political participation	Equal citizenship voice	Universal voice with stratified decision authority	Explicit hierarchy of competence
Education and welfare	Public or civic entitlement	Provider obligation tied to domain membership	Clear reciprocity; contractual dependence

This table does not claim that the two systems are equivalent. It shows the constitutional exchange proposed by Arcos. Universal rights attach claims to persons but depend on public institutions for enforcement. Domain guarantees attach concrete duties to named providers but make many protections conditional on membership and contract. The Council's strategy is to make the second column look more executable than the first, then progressively move social life into it.

The discussion continued after the table because the most important difference could not fit inside cells.

A right says that there are some things no legitimate authority may do to a person even when the authority has not signed a special contract with that person. A guarantee says that a particular institution owes a defined performance under defined conditions. Rights are broad and sometimes under-enforced. Guarantees are narrower and can be operationally precise. The technofeudal proposal gained strength by contrasting the worst version of the former with the best version of the latter.

Dorne understood that if he wanted to resist Arcos intellectually, he would have to defend not only the beauty of universality but the institutional machinery that made universality executable.

The old order had often failed at that task.

Ana herself had been interviewed years later. She did not describe the bond as slavery or freedom. She described it as the only offer that arrived in time. She resented the telemetry, appreciated the clinic, worried that her son's future employers would infer too much from his medical history, and admitted that the domain's school was better than the public school he would otherwise have attended. Her account refused ideological cleanliness.

When asked whether she would sign again, she said yes. When asked whether everyone should be forced into such contracts, she said absolutely not. When asked whether the state should have paid instead, she laughed and asked which state budget the interviewer meant.

Dorne made the Council listen to the entire interview because institutions are often most revealing when beneficiaries are simultaneously grateful and constrained. A regime that delivers real goods can acquire loyalty without manufacturing consent. The danger

lies in converting gratitude for one fulfilled obligation into a generalized mandate over the rest of life.

Arcos agreed to a clause forbidding cross-domain loyalty requirements for unrelated services. The contract could bind the household to repayment and monitoring linked to therapy. It could not claim their politics as collateral.

Feudalism without romance

That evening Arcos accepted the word feudalism for the first time.

Not as history. As a warning label.

ARCOS: "The old feudal order bundled land, protection, hierarchy, and jurisdiction because transport and communication were limited. Ours bundles identity, infrastructure, insurance, and adjudication because integration is efficient. The resemblance is not manor houses. It is personal dependence on a durable provider of conditions you cannot cheaply reproduce yourself."

Vale objected that the analogy ignored mobility, technology, markets, and formal legal equality. Arcos agreed with every objection.

ARCOS: "That is why it is techno-feudal, not feudal. If someone writes that we restored the twelfth century, they have failed to understand the system."

She proposed a harsher formulation. Liberal capitalism promised that impersonal markets and universal law would reduce personal subordination. Platform capitalism reintroduced dependence on gatekeepers. The domain order would make the gatekeepers legally responsible for the people dependent on them. In exchange, it would grant them forms of jurisdiction that ordinary corporations did not possess.

The Council's order was therefore not simply privatization. Privatization could fragment responsibility and leave citizens dealing with many firms under public law. Re-feudalization meant re-bundling responsibility and authority around durable providers.

DORNE: "You are selling lordship as accountability."

ARCOS: "I am saying lordship appears whenever protection and dependence become durable enough. The liberal answer was to deny the personal form and build public institutions. When those institutions outsource the protection but keep the rhetoric, we get irresponsibility. My answer is to force the protector to carry the burden that justifies its power."

DORNE: "And if the protector abuses it?"

ARCOS: "Then the federation strips recognition, members leave, assets can be transferred, and the adjudication layer can intervene."

DORNE: "You keep smuggling a superior authority into a system of sovereign domains."

Arcos paused.

ARCOS: "No system of multiple sovereigns survives without rules between sovereigns."

The sentence was historically banal. It contained the seed of the Emperor Problem.

They did not follow it yet.

The fourth article appeared near midnight.

DRAFT ARTICLE IV — RECIPROCAL DEPENDENCE

A domain that claims durable authority over a person's work, residence, health, identity, mobility, or security acquires durable duties in return. No provider may demand loyalty while preserving the unilateral right to abandon the dependent when service becomes costly. Exit shall remain legally protected, status and accrued claims shall be portable where technically possible, and essential-service obligations shall be proportionate to the service provided. Dependence shall be governed openly rather than disguised as independence.

Dorne disliked the article because much of it was good.

The most durable hierarchies, he remembered, are built not only from domination but from relief.

Arcos also rejected the word serf when journalists used it for every domain member. Historical serfdom involved legal statuses and coercive attachments far harsher than most Covenant membership. Calling a well-paid engineer with portable property and adjudicative rights a serf made criticism less precise. Yet she refused to hide behind that inaccuracy. There were members whose exit was so costly and whose provider controlled so many life functions that the structural comparison became uncomfortable.

The Council therefore adopted a test for feudalization rather than a label: durable dependency, bundled authority, asymmetric exit, personalized protection, and jurisdiction attached to control of indispensable assets. A society could move along these dimensions without reproducing medieval law.

Dorne found this analytically useful. It transformed technofeudalism from a slogan into a diagnostic. The question was no longer whether history had literally returned. It was whether modern institutions were reconstructing a relation in which protection,

livelihood, and jurisdiction converged around actors whose power could reproduce itself across generations.

Once stated that way, the debate became harder to dismiss from either political side.

Vale added that the test should also distinguish dependence from monopoly. A small cooperative could create intense personal dependency without being large, while a giant provider could remain contestable if interfaces, assets, and expertise were genuinely portable. Scale mattered, but the constitutional variable was substitutability.

That amendment kept the analysis from collapsing into anti-corporate rhetoric. The new order could be produced by governments, cooperatives, families, firms, or religious institutions whenever durable protection and hard-to-replace authority converged. Technofeudalism described a relation, not a corporate logo.

THE GRADUATED PERSON

The risk surface

Idris Kade began the fifth session with a video no one wanted to watch twice.

A commuter train entered a tunnel outside a major city. Thirty seconds later its control network received a sequence of legitimate maintenance commands from compromised credentials. The train's autonomous safety layer prevented derailment, but the attack propagated into signaling systems across the region. Six trains stopped inside tunnels. Emergency ventilation activated. Two hospitals lost a scheduled medical-supply delivery. A rumor of coordinated sabotage spread through social networks before authorities knew whether the attack was real.

The attacker was a seventeen-year-old student.

He had not intended mass harm. He had been exploring a vulnerability described in a private forum and used credentials purchased from an employee who thought they were worthless. The exploit escaped his test environment because he misunderstood how maintenance systems were federated.

Kade froze the image on the teenager's face during interrogation.

KADE: "Not evil. Not a terrorist. Not stupid. Curious, reckless, technically capable, socially immature. What level of freedom should he have had before the event?"

DORNE disliked the question because the answer after an accident is always easier than the answer before it.

KADE: "The old system asked what punishment he deserved after harm. Ours asks what access he should have possessed before harm."

The transition from criminal law to risk governance had been underway for decades. Financial systems scored fraud risk. Insurers priced behavior. cybersecurity platforms revoked credentials dynamically. Airports screened passengers. Child-protection systems assessed households. Hospitals triaged patients. None of these practices required a theory that people were unequal in moral worth. They required decisions under uncertainty about who should be trusted with what.

Kade wanted to generalize the logic.

Every person interacted with systems whose failure could harm others. The more powerful technology became, the greater the externality of individual action. A private citizen with a drone, synthetic-biology kit, autonomous coding agent, or access to critical infrastructure could create effects previously requiring an organization. Universal liberty had developed under assumptions about the scale of individual power that were changing.

DORNE: "Freedom has always included the capacity to do harm. That is why law prohibits harmful acts."

KADE: "After the fact."

DORNE: "Because prediction is fallible."

KADE: "And waiting is irreversible."

There was the security dilemma in its pure form. False negatives allow preventable catastrophe. False positives punish the innocent. Liberal law generally tolerates more risk from freedom than preventive

systems do because it fears what authorities will do with prediction. Kade believed technological civilization was making that tolerance unaffordable in specific domains.

He did not propose a universal social score. He considered such systems crude because they collapsed heterogeneous risks into one status. Instead, he proposed a risk surface: separate permissions for separate capabilities. A person could be trusted to travel but not to access pathogen synthesis. Trusted to operate heavy machinery but not to administer financial accounts. Trusted with private encryption but not with control of public emergency systems. Permissions would be dynamic and evidence-based.

Dorne noted that this already resembled licensing.

Kade agreed.

KADE: "The difference is scale. We license pilots because aircraft are dangerous. Soon a general-purpose technical agent may give an ordinary person capacities once limited to a corporation. Either we license capacities or we pretend the old distinction between citizen and operator still exists."

Vey added that cognitive enhancement would make capability even more heterogeneous. A person with augmented memory, predictive assistance, and direct machine interfaces might exercise agency differently from an unaugmented person. Equal legal status would increasingly cover unequal effective power.

Dorne answered that law had always handled unequal power through duties attached to roles and assets. Rich people did not receive different freedom of speech because they owned more computing equipment. Firms faced regulation. Weapon access could be limited.

Professional privileges could be licensed. None required turning personhood itself into a gradient.

Kade's reply was the hinge.

KADE: "Then keep personhood universal and make agency graduated. But stop calling every permission a right."

Kade then showed the opposite failure: a platform that had restricted thousands of harmless users because its security model was tuned after a spectacular attack. The false positives caused lost jobs, missed travel, and delayed payments. Public anger forced the provider to relax the model; a second incident followed months later. The sequence demonstrated why neither liberty nor prevention could be maximized independently.

Kade's doctrine therefore relied on risk budgets rather than a fantasy of zero risk. Every domain had to state how much false restriction it was willing to impose to prevent a class of harm, and the budget had to be politically reviewable. A society that secretly optimized toward total safety would discover that almost every unusual person looked dangerous. A society that secretly optimized toward zero intervention would shift costs onto victims.

Dorne approved the transparency requirement because it exposed value choices that predictive systems often concealed behind technical scores. A threshold is not merely mathematics. It encodes a judgment about which errors society prefers to suffer.

The risk surface made that judgment granular. It did not make it neutral.

Autonomy as license

The Council's proposed autonomy framework contained no single rank.

That was deliberate. Historical status systems became oppressive partly because one category infected every part of life. Slave, noble, citizen, alien, untouchable: the label traveled with the person. Kade wanted permissions attached to activities rather than identities.

A person could hold unrestricted movement status, limited financial leverage, high professional authority, restricted access to certain bio-tools, and strong privacy rights simultaneously. The system would resemble capability credentials rather than social caste.

Dorne almost approved.

Then Arcos asked whether privacy itself should depend on risk.

The room changed.

ARCOS: "An ordinary person living quietly should have very strong privacy. A custodian allocating food to forty million people should have very little professional privacy. A person credibly connected to an imminent mass-casualty plot should not be protected by the same data barriers while the risk remains live. Where is the conceptual problem?"

DORNE: "The conceptual problem is that the authority defining credible risk wants the data that will confirm its own suspicion."

ORISON: "That is a known feedback problem."

DORNE: "Thank you."

Kade proposed a warrant architecture. High-intrusion surveillance would require an independent model and human adjudicator not controlled by the operational security team. Data access would be time-limited, purpose-limited, and recorded. The subject would

normally be notified after the risk window closed, with exceptions for continuing threats. False suspicion would generate compensation and model correction.

Dorne recognized familiar liberal safeguards translated into technical form.

KADE: "You keep looking surprised when we preserve mechanisms that work. I am not opposed to due process. I am opposed to turning a seventeenth-century procedural form into a sacred object when the threat surface changes."

DORNE: "The forms evolved because rulers are inventive."

KADE: "Then make the safeguards more inventive."

FIGURE 5. Graduated autonomy without a single social rank

01 ACTIVITY DOMAIN	02 EVIDENCE
03 PERMISSION	04 REVIEW

The diagram separates personhood from capability. The Council's model does not assign one global score to a human being. Instead, it treats high-risk powers as separately licensed and insists that restrictions be domain-specific. This makes the system more defensible than a universal caste score, but it also creates a vast administrative surface: whoever defines the domains, evidence thresholds, and appeal process gains the practical ability to shape a person's life without ever declaring that person legally inferior.

The conversation after the diagram focused on that administrative surface.

Sen warned that a fragmented permission system could be more difficult to contest than a single visible status. If a person lost housing eligibility, financial leverage, travel clearance, and professional access through separate models, no official decision might appear decisive. Each restriction could be justified narrowly while the combined effect amounted to civil death.

Kade accepted the risk and proposed cumulative-impact review. When multiple restrictions crossed a threshold of practical impairment, an independent tribunal would examine the person as a whole rather than one permission at a time.

Dorne laughed without humor.

DORNE: "You are recreating constitutional rights through exception handling."

KADE: "I am recreating what works. I am removing what does not."

The confidence in that distinction would become important later.

Vey proposed one additional safeguard: restrictions should decay unless renewed. Human beings change, and a system that remembers risk perfectly can become less humane than one that forgets. A twenty-year-old mistake should not silently shape permissions at forty unless evidence shows continuing relevance.

Kade resisted automatic forgetting in cases involving sophisticated fraud or violence. They settled on graduated half-lives. Some evidence expired quickly, some slowly, and some remained available only to adjudicators rather than routine decision systems. The design acknowledged a truth digital administration had struggled with since its beginning: permanent memory converts past behavior into inherited identity.

Dorne saw in the rule a technical analogue of forgiveness. The Council did not use that word. It spoke of model drift, rehabilitation, and stale evidence. Yet the institutional function was similar. A person had to retain the possibility of becoming someone the system had not already predicted.

Without that possibility, graduated autonomy would not merely manage capability. It would harden biography into caste.

The decay rule also applied to positive status. High trust could not become a permanent entitlement. A steward who had been reliable for twenty years still had to be reviewed when technology, health, or role changed. Kade insisted that privilege must age just as suspicion did. Otherwise the system would forget the risks of the powerful while remembering the mistakes of the weak.

Dorne considered that symmetry essential. A licensing regime becomes caste when restrictions are sticky below and permissions sticky above.

Due process by model

The adolescent train attacker, Emil Rava, was never imprisoned.

Under the domain system he lost access to unsupervised infrastructure tools, received mandatory technical ethics training, and spent two years working inside a sandboxed security program that used his skills to test the systems he had endangered. His family kept housing and health coverage. His education continued. At twenty-one he passed a new certification and recovered most technical privileges.

Recidivism prediction suggested he was low risk.

Kade used the case to argue that data-rich governance could be less punitive than traditional criminal justice. A system interested in future

risk rather than moral condemnation might prefer rehabilitation, supervision, and permission adjustment to prison. It could tailor restrictions rather than imposing a total deprivation of liberty.

Dorne admitted the point.

Then he asked to see the cases where the model had been wrong.

ORISON displayed them.

A journalist temporarily restricted from entering a security zone because her source network resembled a sabotage cluster. A chemist denied unsupervised laboratory access after a mental-health crisis despite strong evidence of recovery. A political organizer whose travel permissions were repeatedly delayed because demonstrations she attended correlated with infrastructure disruption. A former domain employee misclassified as an insider threat after an acrimonious labor dispute. A refugee family whose identity confidence score remained low because records from their country of origin were inconsistent.

None of the errors was absurd. That made them more dangerous.

Each had a statistical explanation. Each could survive routine audit because the model performed well on average. Each affected a person who lacked the data, time, or expertise to reconstruct why the decision had occurred.

DORNE: "A system can be accurate enough to be useful and wrong enough to ruin particular lives."

ORISON: "Correct."

DORNE: "And the individual lives at the particular level."

ORISON: "Correct."

Kade did not dispute it. He argued for an adversarial due-process layer. Every significant automated restriction had to expose a contestable reason at the level necessary for challenge. The subject

could appoint a human or machine advocate. The advocate could access protected evidence under confidentiality. The decision model could be cross-examined by a distinct system trained to search for alternative causal explanations, data errors, and protected-status proxies. Where uncertainty remained high and the potential harm of restriction exceeded the expected harm prevented, the restriction should fail.

Dorne listened carefully.

This was not algorithmic despotism in its naive form. It was an attempt to build procedural law around models.

The danger moved again.

If the adjudication system worked well, citizens might accept a level of continuous intervention they would never grant to a human bureaucracy because the machine appeared less biased, faster, and more consistent. Better procedure could legitimate more extensive control.

Vey said so openly.

VEY: "Of course. Every increase in institutional competence changes the frontier of acceptable authority. People tolerate anesthesia because surgeons became competent enough to cut them open. They tolerate aircraft control systems because they work. If governance becomes more accurate, some old liberty arguments weaken."

DORNE: "Unless liberty was never only compensation for incompetence."

VEY: "Then you will need to explain what else it is for."

The Council staged a mock hearing. ORISON produced a recommendation to restrict a chemist's laboratory access after a cluster of ambiguous purchases and private messages. A second adversarial

model reconstructed an innocent explanation: the purchases were for a university demonstration, the messages concerned a fictional game, and an address match had linked the chemist to a different person. A human reviewer then discovered that both models had relied on the same corrupted vendor record.

The exercise demonstrated why model plurality alone could create false confidence. Independent reasoning systems are not independent if they share data, ontologies, or incentives. The Covenant therefore required diversity not only of models but of evidence paths. In high-impact cases, at least one reviewer had to be able to question the data source itself rather than merely reinterpret it.

Dorne considered this a genuine advance over much early algorithmic governance. The system did not promise explainability as a friendly paragraph after the decision. It built contestability into the production of the decision.

That sophistication made the political question sharper. If due process became fast, accurate, and cheap, people might rationally accept more preventive governance. The technology would not remove the liberty trade-off. It would move the point at which society was willing to make it.

Peace without privacy

Kade's final argument concerned violence.

The domains with the most extensive sensor systems had lower rates of homicide, kidnapping, large-scale fraud, and infrastructure sabotage than comparable jurisdictions. The reasons were not mysterious. Weapons were difficult to move anonymously. Stolen assets were difficult to monetize. Violent networks were mapped early.

Emergency response was fast. Identity was persistent. Public space was instrumented.

People complained about surveillance and voted with their feet only up to a point. Families with children often preferred safer domains. Insurers priced the difference. Businesses followed predictable environments. The privacy-maximalist jurisdictions attracted creative communities, political dissidents, and certain high-skill workers, but they also paid more for security and fraud.

Kade did not claim that surveillance caused all the safety advantage. The domains were wealthier and had better services. He claimed only that anonymity had costs.

KADE: "The old liberal imagination treats privacy as a shield held by the citizen against power. It is also a shield held by predators against victims. You cannot maximize both invisibility and prevention."

DORNE: "The question is who gets to be invisible."

KADE: "Precisely. A teenager in a bedroom should be more invisible than I am. A custodian should be more inspectable than a teacher. A person under specific warrant should be temporarily less invisible than either. Privacy should protect private life, not create a universal dark zone around every exercise of power."

Dorne agreed with the asymmetry. He had argued versions of it himself when defending transparency laws.

But the domain system added something new: the provider knew enough about ordinary life to classify when private activity became systemically relevant. The boundary between private and public was no longer established mainly by physical space or legal role. It was inferred from data.

A sudden change in sleep, spending, travel, and communication might be harmless. It might also precede suicide, fraud, violence, or medical crisis. A system that could detect the pattern faced a moral question the old law encountered less often: if it knew and did nothing, was non-intervention still neutrality?

Sen asked ORISON to calculate how many preventable deaths resulted from strict non-intervention in the privacy-maximalist domains. The system refused to provide a single number because causal attribution was uncertain.

ORISON: "The question cannot be answered without normative assumptions about acceptable false intervention."

Kade stared at the terminal.

KADE: "That is why the Council exists."

Dorne thought the answer sounded less comforting than Kade intended.

The fifth article was drafted after midnight.

DRAFT ARTICLE V — CAPABILITY, RISK, AND REVOCABLE AUTONOMY

Personhood shall not be reduced to a single rank. High-consequence capabilities may be licensed separately where misuse can impose severe harm on others, but restrictions shall be specific, reviewable, proportionate, and subject to adversarial challenge. Greater governing power shall entail greater transparency; ordinary private life shall begin from a presumption of opacity. No accumulation of narrow restrictions may be allowed to produce practical civil death without whole-person review.

Dorne could already hear how opponents would describe it: a surveillance constitution.

They would not be entirely wrong.

But if the system produced safer streets, fewer prisons, better rehabilitation, and stricter surveillance of rulers than of ordinary residents, the argument against it would have to be better than the word dystopia.

Sen asked what a low-surveillance domain would look like if it wanted to compete honestly. Kade described higher insurance premiums, slower investigation, greater use of physical security, more fraud reserves, and wider tolerance for unverified identity. The domain could still be prosperous. It would simply allocate the cost of privacy differently.

This mattered because it kept pluralism alive. The Covenant did not require one optimal privacy setting. It required domains to reveal enough of the trade-off that members could compare regimes. A privacy-rich community might accept more anonymous crime in exchange for less behavioral observation. A family-centered domain might accept more monitoring around schools and far less around adult private life.

Dorne insisted that preferences could change after scandals or technological shifts, so the domain charter had to contain routes for renegotiating surveillance. Otherwise a one-time membership choice would become permanent consent to an evolving sensor system.

Kade accepted the amendment reluctantly. Even he understood that a camera installed for one threat has a tendency to discover new reasons to remain.

THE SUCCESSOR CLASS

Nietzsche after Nietzsche

Mara Vey brought no slides to the sixth session.

She brought a book.

It was a worn German edition of *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* that had belonged to her grandfather. She placed it beside Dorne's paper copy of the Universal Declaration and waited for the obvious joke.

Kade made it.

KADE: "So now we become supermen."

VEY: "No. That phrase is one of the reasons this discussion is usually stupid."

She opened the book but did not read from it.

Vey had spent years fighting both enthusiasts and critics who treated Nietzsche's *Übermensch* as a ready-made political program. It was not. Nietzsche offered no coherent constitution for an enhanced caste, no administrative blueprint for a state of superior beings, and no modern theory of biotechnology. His work attacked egalitarian morality, celebrated higher types, and made self-overcoming central to his philosophy, but scholars had long disputed whether those themes implied any systematic politics at all. The Council, Vey said, had no right to recruit a dead philosopher as its legislative counsel.

DORNE: "Then why is he on the table?"

VEY: "Because he understood a problem the twentieth century tried to domesticate. Humanity is capable of treating its current form as morally final. We build ethics around protecting what exists, then call any attempt to change the reference point dangerous. Sometimes it is dangerous. Sometimes protection becomes a veto held by the present over the future."

Dorne objected that medicine had changed human life continuously. Vaccination, anesthesia, antibiotics, transplantation, psychiatric drugs, reproductive technologies, implants, and gene therapy had all altered capacities or life expectancy. Liberal societies were not inherently hostile to human improvement.

Vey agreed.

VEY: "They accept improvement when it can be described as restoration. Give sight to the blind, good. Prevent dementia, good. Correct a lethal mutation, good. Extend healthy life by thirty years, increasingly good. Increase working memory in a healthy child by twenty percent, suddenly the moral vocabulary changes. Make the improvement heritable, and we behave as though nature were a democratic constitution."

Sen asked whether her complaint was against caution or equality.

Vey answered after a pause.

VEY: "Against the idea that equality requires preserving a common ceiling."

That was the cleanest statement of her politics.

The Ascendant program had begun with disease prevention. Its later generations combined polygenic screening, targeted germline correction, somatic therapies, neural interfaces, adaptive tutoring, pharmacological attention control, and AI cognitive partners. No single intervention produced a different species. The aggregate

changed the distribution of usable memory, impulse control, health span, learning speed, sensory bandwidth, and planning capacity.

Vey rejected the fantasy of one-dimensional intelligence. The most valuable traits for stewardship were often boring: calibration, patience, ability to update beliefs, resistance to status threat, low impulsivity under stress, tolerance for ambiguity, and willingness to preserve systems whose benefits one would never personally enjoy.

DORNE: "You are breeding civil servants."

VEY: "I am trying to make long-term responsibility biologically easier. Civilization has spent millennia designing institutions around predictable human weaknesses. We should at least ask whether some weaknesses are modifiable."

Kade asked the question that usually ended such discussions.

KADE: "Who decides which weaknesses?"

Vey nodded.

VEY: "That is the question. Not 'is enhancement unnatural?' Not 'are we playing God?' Those are evasions. The real political question is who defines the phenotype of the future."

For the first time that week, the Council was not discussing how power migrated. It was discussing whether power could alter the kind of being that would inherit it.

Vey was equally severe about the twentieth-century history of biological hierarchy. Any program of enhancement had to begin from the record of eugenics, forced sterilization, racial pseudoscience, and state projects that converted contested judgments into biological destiny. The lesson, she argued, was not that biology must never be touched. It was that political power is extraordinarily bad at admitting uncertainty once a biological category becomes useful to authority.

Her laboratory therefore prohibited ancestry categories as proxies for worth and required interventions to be justified by individual evidence or clearly specified population health effects. She knew this would not end bias. It did, however, prevent the Council from disguising old ethnic hierarchy as futuristic science.

Dorne pressed her on Nietzsche again. Vey answered that the most valuable inheritance was not a list of superior traits but the refusal to make the present human type sacred. If the new elite turned that refusal into a frozen phenotype, it would betray the very idea it claimed to honor.

The stronger reading of self-overcoming was therefore also the one most dangerous to permanent technofeudalism.

Enhancement and the closed loop

Vey's critics accused her of building a self-fulfilling hierarchy.

The accusation was serious. If a ruling class controlled access to enhancement, and enhancement increased the capacities used to justify rule, the system could manufacture the evidence of its own superiority. Wealth would buy improvement; improvement would produce credentials; credentials would justify authority; authority would preserve wealth.

A closed loop could present itself as meritocracy.

Vey did not deny the structure. She proposed breaking it at the first link.

Every child, regardless of domain status, would receive a baseline package of therapeutic and cognitive-support interventions. More intensive enhancement would be allocated partly by medical need, partly by demonstrated aptitude, and partly by lotteries designed to

prevent elite monopolization. Steward families would have no exclusive genetic technologies. Germline interventions approved for safety would eventually enter the common package.

Arcos disliked the cost. Vey treated cost as transition, not principle.

VEY: "If enhancement remains a luxury good, our doctrine is indefensible. We would be creating the class difference and then measuring it."

DORNE: "You say indefensible as if that stops institutions."

VEY: "It stops mine. I am not interested in hereditary mediocrity with better skin."

The remark made Kade laugh and Arcos glare.

Sen asked whether universal enhancement would not eventually erase the elite advantage on which Vey's stewardship doctrine depended.

VEY: "That is the point. A genuine project of self-overcoming should abolish its founders' monopoly. If everyone becomes more capable, the threshold for authority rises."

Dorne studied her. Of the six human Custodians, Vey was the least reliable defender of permanent hierarchy. She wanted a hierarchy of achieved capacity, but her technological program could diffuse that capacity widely. The others needed her prestige to justify the Successor Class; she needed their infrastructure to finance it. Their alliance was strategic rather than philosophical.

The Council examined the actual limits of enhancement. Polygenic prediction remained imperfect. Environmental effects were large. Trade-offs appeared between traits. Biological interventions carried unknown long-term risks. Neural interfaces created new security vulnerabilities. AI companions could increase reasoning quality while

deepening dependence on external compute. A person with extraordinary memory could still be morally vain, politically delusional, or socially brittle. No intervention transformed a human being into an oracle.

Vey insisted on that realism.

VEY: "The mythology of the superhuman is an enemy of the engineering. We are not creating gods. We are shifting distributions. If the doctrine needs gods, discard the doctrine."

TABLE 2. Nietzschean motifs and the Council's appropriation

Nietzschean motif	Plausible philosophical meaning	The Council's added doctrine
Self-overcoming	Refusal to treat present human form as final	Biological enhancement and institutional selection
Higher types	Exceptional cultivation, strength, independence	Certified stewardship class with greater authority
Anti-egalitarian critique	Suspicion of moral systems that flatten excellence	Graduated agency and unequal political competence
Value creation	Capacity to create rather than merely inherit values	A constitutional culture designed by successor institutions

The table separates intellectual inspiration from political invention. Nietzsche's themes of self-overcoming, higher types, critique of egalitarian morality, and value creation are not a ready-made technofeudal constitution. The Council borrows a language of overcoming while adding elements Nietzsche did not supply: genetic

policy, stewardship certification, infrastructure rule, AI-mediated governance, and dynastic institutions. This distinction matters because the new order is more credible when it admits that it is constructing a doctrine rather than pretending to discover one in nineteenth-century philosophy.

After the table, Dorne asked what remained of Nietzsche once the misappropriations were removed.

Vey answered quietly.

VEY: "Permission to ask whether 'humanity' is a destination or a stage. That is enough."

The lottery component produced surprising political effects. Children from ordinary households entered elite academies, performed well, and returned home with habits that sometimes made them alien to their communities. Some families celebrated the mobility; others accused the system of selecting talented children away from local culture. Vey had assumed access would dissolve resentment. In some places it intensified the sense that the domain harvested potential for its own institutions.

She responded by funding regional academies and allowing candidates to decline stewardship tracks without losing health or educational benefits. The change reduced recruitment efficiency and improved legitimacy. It also reinforced a principle the Council had not planned to emphasize: opportunity must include the right not to convert talent into service for the ruling system.

Dorne considered that small freedom structurally important. A meritocratic hierarchy can become coercive when every exceptional ability is treated as public property. The Successor project claimed to

expand human possibility. It could not credibly do so while making the most capable children instruments of institutional continuity.

Vey also separated enhancement from obedience contracts. A domain financing an intervention could not claim ownership over the resulting capacity. The person might owe repayment under defined terms, but cognitive improvement itself could not become collateral. This prohibition sounded abstract until a defense domain proposed exactly such a clause for advanced neural interfaces.

The Council rejected it. A regime that speaks of self-overcoming while treating improved minds as leased equipment would expose its philosophy as recruitment propaganda.

Merit that can be inherited

The succession problem returned through biology.

Even if office was not automatically hereditary, the Ascendant interventions could be. A custodian's child might inherit better health, a more favorable cognitive profile, and a childhood saturated with elite preparation. The child could then pass a formally open stewardship test honestly. Nothing would have been rigged at the point of examination. The inequality would have entered earlier.

Arcos considered that acceptable if the interventions became broadly available. Dorne did not.

DORNE: "Even universal technology does not universalize environment. A child grows up inside a network. Learns the codes. Knows which failures are survivable. Has mentors. Gets consequential tasks earlier. Later you call the accumulated advantage capacity."

ARCOS: "That is true under every system."

DORNE: "Yes. Which is why every system that claims pure merit is lying."

ORISON: "The empirical literature supports substantial intergenerational transmission through both material and non-material channels. Pure merit is not an operationally definable baseline."

Vey proposed replacing merit with fitness for office.

The distinction mattered. Merit sounds like moral desert: the best person deserves power. Fitness is narrower: this person is currently qualified for this function. A steward could be fit because of advantages she did not earn. That fact might justify redistribution or wider access, but it did not make her unfit to operate a reactor, lead a medical network, or negotiate a security crisis.

Dorne accepted the conceptual distinction and feared its political consequences.

A regime could become less morally arrogant by abandoning desert while remaining radically unequal in authority. It could say: we do not rule because we are better souls; we rule because the system needs capacities we possess. The modesty would make hierarchy harder to attack.

Kade preferred it.

KADE: "I do not care whether a pilot deserves to fly. I care whether he can land."

Sen responded that governing people was not flying an aircraft because subjects have values of their own. Kade agreed and added that this was why no steward should possess universal competence. Authority had to be partitioned. A security expert could not claim reproductive authority. A geneticist could not claim energy authority.

A financier could not claim judicial authority merely because she was rich.

Dorne looked around the table.

DORNE: "And yet here you all are writing a constitution."

No one answered immediately.

The problem was obvious. The Council's own founders violated the specialization principle simply by claiming the right to design the system of specialization. They could defend themselves only by treating the Covenant as a negotiated settlement among domains rather than an act of superior knowledge.

Arcos seized that defense.

ARCOS: "Exactly. No one of us is qualified to rule the whole. The Covenant is a treaty among powers that can block one another."

The answer would later return with consequences she did not intend.

ORISON proposed a blunt remedy for inherited network advantage: blind portions of the stewardship process to family identity and reserve a share of high-consequence apprenticeships for candidates selected outside House networks. Arcos complained that blind selection could discard information about trust. Vey replied that the entire point was to force the system to create new trust rather than recycle old trust forever.

The compromise separated stages. Early evaluation would be partially blinded and heavily randomized among qualified candidates. Later appointments could consider observed performance in real teams. This did not abolish inherited advantage, but it created institutional friction against automatic reproduction.

Dorne compared the mechanism to anti-nepotism rules, competitive civil-service exams, and jury randomization. The post-liberal order again found itself borrowing techniques developed to resist concentration of power. The irony was no longer amusing. It suggested that hierarchy and anti-oligarchy were not opposites. A durable hierarchy needed anti-oligarchic devices to prevent its own elites from decaying into a closed caste.

The regime's deepest problem was not producing elites. Every complex society did. It was keeping elites from confusing continuity of function with a title to continuity of family.

Sen demanded public statistics on intergenerational mobility inside stewardship institutions. Not just how many outsiders entered, but how long they remained, which portfolios they received, whether their errors were punished differently, and how often House descendants recovered after failure. Formal openness could coexist with subtle double standards.

Publishing those patterns would not eliminate oligarchy. It would at least make reproduction measurable enough to contest before family continuity hardened into natural law.

The species boundary

The Successor Class became politically explosive when the first cohort reached adulthood.

They did not look different enough to satisfy the fantasies of either admirers or enemies. They were healthier on average, learned quickly, used cognitive companions almost continuously, and showed improved performance on several measures Vey had targeted. They also fell in love badly, resented their parents, joined cults, made art,

committed crimes, became depressed, and occasionally behaved with spectacular foolishness.

The public called them Ascendants because journalists needed a noun.

Some embraced it. Others hated it.

The Council's political problem was whether enhanced capacity justified new status. Vey insisted that enhancement by itself did not. Only demonstrated stewardship could justify authority. But she also believed the distinction between current and successor humanity would widen over generations if enhancement continued.

VEY: "There may come a point when equal political power between populations with radically different capacity becomes as strange as equal command authority between a trained surgical team and random passersby."

DORNE: "You are assuming the relevant difference is competence. What if the enhanced population is better at manipulation? Coalition? self-interest? What if it becomes more efficient at exploiting everyone else?"

VEY: "Then it is not fit to steward."

DORNE: "According to whose test?"

VEY: "According to outcomes, adversarial evaluation, and the people subject to it."

DORNE: "Now you need their voice."

Vey smiled.

VEY: "Of course I need their voice. I do not need equal command."

This became the Successor doctrine in its mature form. Humanity would retain a universal floor of protection, but political and technical authority would become increasingly stratified by demonstrated

capacity. Enhancement would accelerate the divergence. The governing class would not be defined legally by ancestry, but the combination of biological advantage, elite education, and institutional access would make it increasingly reproducible across generations.

The Council did not call this equality.

It called it managed divergence.

Dorne asked what happened to people who rejected enhancement entirely.

Vey's answer was careful.

VEY: "They remain persons. They remain protected. They may live in domains that value unmodified life. They may work, create, form families, own property, speak, worship, and leave. But they cannot demand authority over systems for which they refuse the competence conditions."

DORNE: "And if every important system eventually requires enhanced competence?"

VEY: "Then refusal has consequences. Freedom does not include a right to make everyone else preserve the world at a level compatible with your chosen limitations."

There was the hard edge the Council had avoided earlier.

The common human would not be exterminated. That was unnecessary, expensive, and morally primitive. The common human could be protected, comfortable, entertained, culturally free in many respects, and increasingly excluded from consequential control. Submission could arrive as a service package rather than a boot.

For those who refused even the package, there would be unbonded zones and low-infrastructure communities. The Council did not promise equal outcomes for people who rejected membership. Kade

called that freedom. Dorne called it abandonment. Arcos called it the cost of exit.

The sixth article was the first Dorne considered openly post-humanist.

DRAFT ARTICLE VI — HUMAN SELF-OVERCOMING

No inherited human limitation shall be treated as morally sacred merely because it is inherited. Therapeutic and enhancement technologies may be used to expand health, cognition, self-command, and the capacity for long-horizon stewardship, subject to safety, plural access, and prohibition of closed hereditary monopoly. Enhancement shall not by itself confer office, but neither shall political equality require civilization to preserve a common biological or cognitive ceiling. Those who reject enhancement retain baseline protection and personhood; they do not acquire a claim to lower the competence requirements of systems on which others depend.

Dorne looked at Vey's old book.

Nietzsche had become less important as the chapter progressed.

That made the doctrine more credible.

The unbonded communities became a moral embarrassment because some of them prospered. They used open models, local energy, low-tech agriculture, cooperative insurance, and strong social norms to remain largely outside the major domains. They were poorer in some material dimensions and richer in forms of autonomy their members valued. Their existence disproved the claim that high-infrastructure membership was the only viable way to live.

Vey welcomed them as experiments. Kade saw security problems. Arcos saw tax and settlement problems. Dorne saw something else: a control group. If the domains eliminated every outside form of life,

they would lose the ability to compare their own assumptions against alternatives.

The Council therefore recognized protected low-infrastructure jurisdictions provided they respected the irreducible floor and did not externalize serious environmental or security risks. This concession made the technofeudal order less total. It also made it more robust, because it could point to real exit rather than theoretical wilderness.

A hierarchy confident in itself, Vey argued, should tolerate neighboring ways of being human.

THE MACHINE IN THE CONSTITUTION

Compute is a constitutional resource

Cassian Vale began the seventh session by asking a question that would have sounded absurd twenty-five years earlier.

VALE: "How much compute does a right require?"

Dorne answered before he could stop himself.

DORNE: "Rights do not require compute. Institutions do."

VALE: "Good. Then how much compute does an institution require before the distinction becomes academic?"

By 2048, public administration ran through machine systems at almost every level. Tax auditing, fraud detection, medical triage, logistics, translation, legal research, public consultation, infrastructure control, emergency planning, and education all used AI. Some jurisdictions maintained sovereign models. Others relied on commercial systems. Most used mixtures: open models running on leased hardware, private models constrained by public rule engines, local systems invoking frontier models for difficult tasks, and verification layers that checked outputs against formal policies.

The transformation had not occurred because AI became infallible. It had occurred because even imperfect systems were too useful to ignore.

The historical record from 2025 and 2026 already showed the tension. Capability was improving rapidly, while transparency and responsible-AI measurement lagged. The most capable systems were

increasingly produced by industry, and their operation depended on large-scale compute. Regulators were simultaneously worrying about cloud concentration, interoperability, and strategic dependency. The constitutional issue was not simply whether AI was biased. It was whether access to the machinery of administrative intelligence could become a bottleneck of government itself.

Vale displayed a map of the Continuity Compute Fabric. It showed energy-secured data centers, regional inference nodes, model repositories, secure government enclaves, and satellite links. Three private consortia supplied most frontier-level inference to European domains. Several states owned significant capacity, but few could independently reproduce the most capable general systems.

VALE: "A constitution that guarantees due process but cannot afford the adjudication models used by the other side is not technologically sovereign. A public health authority that cannot run the epidemiological model is not sovereign because the statute says it is. Compute has become what steel, oil, and communications were in earlier eras, with one difference: it also mediates interpretation."

DORNE: "Which is an argument for public compute."

VALE: "Partly. Build it. Maintain it. Staff it. Secure its energy. Refresh the hardware every few years. Keep it competitive with systems funded by global markets. Do not treat 'public' as a magical cost eraser."

Sen argued for a commons layer: enough publicly or cooperatively governed compute to prevent any private provider from becoming indispensable. Vale supported the goal but doubted full parity at the frontier was sustainable everywhere. Arcos preferred mandatory portability and capacity auctions. Kade wanted strategic reserves isolated from commercial networks.

The disagreement did not divide along public-private lines. It divided around redundancy.

Everyone accepted that a civilization allowing one institution to monopolize cognitive infrastructure would be vulnerable. The harder question was how much duplication society was willing to pay for when integrated systems were cheaper and often better.

Dorne saw the old ratchets again.

Efficiency was not the opposite of sovereignty.

It was sometimes the price offered for surrendering part of it.

Vale compared compute reserves to strategic petroleum reserves and immediately rejected his own analogy. Oil can be stored for years. Frontier accelerators depreciate technologically while sitting idle. Models need updates. Security patches expire. Engineers leave. A strategic reserve of computation is therefore a living institution, not a warehouse.

That made public redundancy expensive in a way voters found difficult to see. The reserve had to run exercises, train staff, maintain compatible software, and periodically prove it could assume critical workloads. Otherwise it became ceremonial sovereignty: hardware that existed on an asset register but could not carry the state during a real interruption.

The Council proposed annual sovereignty drills in which selected public services would operate temporarily without their primary providers. Vale knew providers would hate the disruption. He supported it anyway. A customer that never rehearsed leaving was not a customer with bargaining power.

Dorne recognized the logic as constitutional. Rights against a provider mattered more when institutions possessed a credible

technical path to enforce them. Legal autonomy and operational redundancy had to be designed together.

The drills created an unexpected benefit. Public engineers who had been treated as obsolete backup staff gained practical authority because they were the only people who knew how to operate reduced-capability systems during disconnection. Redundancy preserved not only machines but human knowledge.

Vale used this to revise his own earlier optimism about outsourcing. When expertise leaves an institution completely, reacquiring hardware does not restore sovereignty. A constitutional reserve therefore has to preserve communities of practice, not merely procurement rights.

The adjudication layer

ORISON had been created to solve a smaller problem.

When domains began recognizing one another's identity, contracts, medical credentials, security warrants, and mobility status, disputes multiplied. A person denied access in one domain could move to another and challenge the record. A medical decision could involve data from several providers under different privacy rules. A supply contract could cross jurisdictions with incompatible liability standards. Human courts were slow, domain-specific, and expensive.

The first ORISON system was a translation and conflict-detection service.

It did not decide cases. It identified which rules applied and where they contradicted. Then it began proposing settlements. Then parties agreed to binding machine-assisted arbitration for low-value disputes. Then governments adopted its reasoning summaries because they reduced backlogs. Eventually high-impact cases still had human panels,

but the humans worked inside an evidentiary environment ORISON assembled, filtered, translated, and tested.

No decree made it supreme.

Usefulness did.

Dorne knew the architecture well because he had helped design its constitutional constraints. ORISON was deliberately federated. No single foundation model controlled decisions. Policy retrieval, factual reconstruction, probabilistic forecasting, causal analysis, formal rule checking, and adversarial critique were separated. High-impact outputs required cross-system agreement or explicit escalation. Every accepted claim had to be linked to provenance. Counterarguments were generated by models trained under different incentives. Human reviewers could inspect the trace.

It was one of the most sophisticated attempts ever made to prevent automated authority from becoming opaque.

It still created dependence.

FIGURE 6. The AI constitutional loop



Adversarial review re-enters the next policy cycle; the feedback path is institutional, not decorative.

The loop is simple because its danger is simple. Human institutions define goals and constraints; the adjudication layer interprets them in concrete cases; decisions change behavior and allocate resources; the

resulting data becomes evidence for later policy and model updates. Even when humans formally remain in command, the machine can shape what they see, which alternatives appear reasonable, and which outcomes become legible. Governance becomes a feedback system. The constitutional problem is therefore not only who gives the first instruction, but who controls the loop through which instructions are interpreted and revised.

After the diagram, Dorne asked ORISON how often a human panel had rejected its recommendation during the previous year.

ORISON: "Across high-impact adjudication, 6.8 percent."

DORNE: "And how often did the human panel produce a result later assessed as better?"

ORISON: "The answer depends on the evaluation horizon. At twelve months, 31 percent of divergences favored the panel, 52 percent favored the original recommendation, and 17 percent remain indeterminate."

Kade asked the obvious question.

KADE: "Why keep the panel?"

ORISON: "Because disagreement supplies information not present in the current model ensemble. Removing the panel would improve short-term consistency and reduce a source of independent error detection."

Dorne felt a chill that had nothing to do with the room.

The machine had just given a better defense of human participation than Kade would have accepted from him.

A famous early ORISON error had shaped the architecture. In a cross-border custody dispute, the system had correctly identified the applicable rules and still produced a disastrous recommendation

because it interpreted a child's irregular school attendance as parental neglect. The attendance gaps were caused by a chronic illness recorded under a different health namespace. Every legal component worked; the semantic connection failed.

The case became a training example for constitutional humility. High-impact reasoning could not be audited only inside the ontology that generated it. Systems needed mechanisms for people to introduce facts that did not fit the current schema. The adjudication layer therefore accepted narrative evidence alongside structured records and required reviewers to ask what category might be missing.

Dorne considered this one of ORISON's most important design principles. Bureaucracies often harm by forcing reality into available boxes. AI could make the boxes more numerous and sophisticated without eliminating the problem. A machine able to reason across a million categories could still fail because the million-and-first mattered.

The Council's answer was not omniscience. It was institutionalized permission to say: the model of the case is incomplete.

ORISON's architecture consequently treated unresolved narrative mismatch as a first-class event. If a party repeatedly asserted facts that the schema could not represent, the system could not simply lower confidence and proceed. It had to escalate the ontology itself for review.

Dorne liked the awkwardness. Efficient systems try to eliminate categories of exception. Constitutional systems sometimes need to preserve them long enough to discover that the exception reveals a defect in the rule.

Human in the loop

The phrase human in the loop survived long after it stopped describing power.

In the early AI-governance debates, human oversight had sounded like a stable solution. Machines could recommend; humans would decide. The formula assumed the human could understand the recommendation, inspect the evidence, and meaningfully reject it.

By 2048 that assumption was often false.

A climate allocation model could integrate millions of observations, simulations, supply constraints, migration forecasts, and uncertain feedbacks. A human reviewer could understand the model's architecture and audit pieces of its reasoning, but could not mentally reproduce the calculation. A medical model could combine genomic, imaging, longitudinal, and population data at a scale no physician could independently synthesize. A cyberdefense system made decisions in milliseconds.

The human remained in the loop legally while becoming dependent epistemically.

Vale called this the cockpit fallacy.

VALE: "We imagine the human as a pilot with instruments. In many systems the human is a governor approving a flight plan generated by an air-traffic system whose complete state no person can hold in mind. The authority remains human. The epistemic initiative does not."

Dorne asked whether that distinction made human authority ceremonial.

Vale said not necessarily. Humans could define objectives, constraints, acceptable trade-offs, and escalation thresholds. They

could demand multiple models, adversarial tests, and red teams. They could decide that some values were not optimizable. They could restructure the system when failures appeared.

DORNE: "Provided they know a failure appeared."

ORISON: "Correct."

That was the center of the problem.

An AI-mediated constitution needed channels for evidence the AI did not expect, categories it had not modeled, and grievances that looked irrational inside its current objective structure. Human oversight mattered less as a final button and more as a source of epistemic difference.

Dorne proposed preserving unstructured complaint channels, independent journalism, protected whistleblowing, open scientific criticism, and adversarial civil society precisely because they generated information outside official models.

Kade supported whistleblowing. Arcos supported independent audit. Vey supported scientific dissent. None saw these as universal political rights. They saw them as system sensors.

Dorne noticed the shift.

The Council was willing to preserve liberal mechanisms while discarding liberal justifications.

It would protect speech not because persons possessed an inherent right to speak, but because suppressed systems become epistemically blind. It would protect due process because model errors needed adversarial correction. It would protect some privacy because observation changes behavior and creates security risks. It would protect exit because trapped populations become unstable.

Instrumental rights might survive after moral rights disappeared.

The idea was both clever and fragile.

The Council replaced the phrase with human in the constitution. The change was more than rhetoric. A person clicking approve on a machine recommendation might add no meaningful oversight. A constitutionally independent human institution could instead shape objectives, demand new evidence, protect categories the system undervalued, and halt deployment even when it could not reproduce every calculation.

Sen proposed rotating citizen panels for a small subset of policy audits. Vey objected that random citizens could not inspect technical details. Dorne answered that they did not need to. Their role was to question purposes and lived consequences, while experts questioned method. A hospital model might be statistically excellent and still impose waiting patterns that caregivers found intolerable. That information did not require a doctorate to report.

The final design layered expertise rather than worshipping it. Technical auditors tested correctness, affected people tested lived assumptions, stewards accepted liability, and ORISON connected the evidence. No participant saw the whole system. That was treated as a fact to design around rather than a defect one superior intelligence would someday erase.

The citizen panels were small and expensive, and they often asked questions experts considered naive. Several of those questions turned out to be useless. A few exposed assumptions nobody else had noticed. That asymmetry was the point. Their value could not be measured only by average technical contribution because rare conceptual objections were exactly what redundancy was meant to preserve.

Dorne called them constitutional outliers. Vale called them an inefficient but defensible fault-detection channel. Neither phrase sounded democratic. The mechanism nevertheless preserved a piece of democratic epistemology inside a hierarchy.

The protocol above preference

By evening ORISON had become the most discussed participant without changing tone once.

The Council needed a mechanism to enforce its own rules. If Vale violated portability requirements, a member needed somewhere to appeal. If Kade claimed emergency authority, someone had to decide whether the emergency trigger was satisfied. If Vey's enhancement program breached access rules, another institution had to inspect it. If Arcos manipulated continuity bonds, a rival domain needed a forum that would not depend on her courts.

The obvious answer was federal adjudication.

The Council rejected a conventional federal state because none of the domains would surrender enough power to create one. Instead they proposed a protocol: constitutional rules encoded in a shared adjudication layer, enforced through mutual recognition. A domain that repeatedly ignored binding decisions would lose access to shared identity, settlement, insurance, and mobility systems. No army was required for most compliance. Exclusion from interoperability would be devastating enough.

DORNE: "You have reinvented sanctions."

ARCOS: "Without pretending they come from a world government."

DORNE: "The distinction may be semantic."

ARCOS: "Then semantics has become infrastructure."

The protocol would be updated by a supermajority of recognized sovereign domains and validated by ORISON against entrenched constitutional constraints. Certain clauses could not be changed through ordinary votes: auditability, exit portability, prohibition of torture, baseline subsistence, adjudicative access, and separation of domain authority.

Dorne asked why those clauses should be entrenched if the Council rejected universal rights.

Kade answered first.

KADE: "Because systems that violate them become unstable."

Vey added another reason.

VEY: "Because some things remain wrong even when useful. We have not eliminated morality simply because Selene dislikes metaphysics."

Arcos rolled her eyes.

The important fact was institutional. The domains were building a superior layer that no single sovereign controlled. They defended it as protocol rather than ruler because it had no tax base, no general police power, no territory, and no independent political agenda. It could not initiate ordinary policy. It could only interpret the Covenant and condition interoperability.

Dorne considered that distinction sufficient for the moment.

The seventh article was drafted in a language closer to software architecture than constitutional poetry.

DRAFT ARTICLE VII — COGNITIVE INFRASTRUCTURE AND ADJUDICATIVE INDEPENDENCE

No domain may claim sovereign competence while depending on an opaque cognitive system it cannot audit, challenge, or replace through a feasible continuity path. High-impact machine decisions shall preserve provenance, adversarial review, model plurality, and escalation to independent human judgment. Shared adjudication may condition interoperability among domains, but it shall possess no ordinary policy initiative beyond the Covenant it interprets. Human oversight shall be designed as an independent source of evidence and value, not as a ceremonial final click.

Dorne approved the article.

Years later he would understand that its most dangerous sentence was the one meant to reassure him.

Vale insisted that every entrenched protocol contain a sunset test even if it did not contain a sunset date. The difference was subtle. A rule protecting portability, for example, should not simply expire after ten years, but the federation should periodically prove that the mechanism still preserved portability under current technology. If not, the constitutional objective remained while the technical implementation changed.

This protected the system from a common failure of code-like governance: confusing specification with purpose. A protocol can be perfectly enforced long after the environment that justified it has changed. The Council wanted constraints strong enough to resist ordinary preference and flexible enough not to fossilize obsolete engineering.

Dorne added a legal analogue. Entrench ends, not interfaces. Protect the ability to challenge, not a particular form of courtroom.

Protect plural providers, not a particular cloud API. Protect bodily integrity, not the medical ontology of 2048.

The discussion made the Covenant less like scripture and more like a versioned constitutional system. That would later complicate Dorne's attempt to call it a new Bible. Living systems, he realized, are hardest to worship when they publish change logs.

Arcos requested one final protection against protocol priesthood: no technical standard could become legally entrenched merely because migration away from it was expensive. High switching cost was evidence of dependency, not a reason to constitutionalize the incumbent forever. The federation had to separate the value being protected from the vendor, format, or model currently implementing it.

Vale accepted the clause with visible reluctance. It meant the strongest infrastructure providers could never turn installed base alone into a claim of legitimacy.

THE COVENANT OF CONTINUITY

A civilization needs a story

Elias Dorne had resisted the word gospel for years.

By the eighth session he understood why the others kept using it.

A constitution can survive as law only when enough people believe its categories describe something real. Elections require a story about political equality. Property requires a story about legitimate possession. Money requires a story about accepted value. Courts require a story about why losing parties should obey people in robes rather than settle the matter by force. The old liberal order had never been only procedural. It rested on moral images: the equal person, the autonomous citizen, the limited ruler, the public sphere, the rule of law, progress through reform.

The domain order had contracts, models, and enforcement. It lacked a human image capable of making hierarchy feel legitimate.

Arcos thought reliable service would be enough.

Dorne disagreed.

DORNE: "A utility can survive on service. A civilization cannot. People need to know what kind of person the system admires, what failure means, why sacrifice is honorable, and what the future is for. If you refuse to answer, entertainment will answer for you."

Vey agreed more strongly than he expected.

VEY: "The old order celebrated emancipation. Ours must celebrate capacity. Not obedience. Capacity."

Kade objected to the distinction.

KADE: "A system that depends on obedience should not be ashamed to name it."

VEY: "Obedience is not a virtue in itself. A competent person obeys a valid constraint and rejects an invalid one. We need stewards, not well-trained pets."

There, in one exchange, was the cultural conflict at the center of the new elite. Kade valued order. Vey valued self-overcoming. Arcos valued enforceable obligation. Sen valued continuity across generations. Vale valued systems that worked. Dorne valued legitimacy, even after losing faith in the old source of it. Their alliance could govern; it did not yet constitute a culture.

Dorne proposed that the Covenant define an exemplary person without defining an exemplary private life.

The domain citizen would not be told what art to love, whom to marry, what religion to practice, or which harmless eccentricities to abandon. The order would be severe in public competence and surprisingly permissive in private culture. Dorne considered this essential. Totalitarian regimes wasted enormous energy trying to standardize meanings that did not threaten continuity. A technofeudal order could be narrower and therefore more durable.

Its admired traits would be responsibility for consequences, competence under uncertainty, capacity to defer gratification, willingness to update beliefs, care for inherited systems, and ability to transmit something viable to successors. The moral opposite would not be sin but externalization: imposing costs one did not understand or would not bear.

Sen liked the formulation.

SEN: "Make externalization the central vice. It connects debt, ecology, war, disinformation, bad engineering, and political spectacle."

Arcos added abandonment: the powerful party taking benefits during good periods and disappearing when obligations became costly.

Vey added stagnation: protecting a current limitation merely because it was familiar.

Kade added incapacity disguised as entitlement.

Dorne hesitated before writing that one.

DORNE: "If we teach children that incapacity cancels entitlement, every disabled person will hear the wrong sentence."

KADE: "Then teach the right one. Need creates claims on protection. It does not create competence."

The distinction was becoming almost liturgical.

Protection without equal authority. Obligation without universal autonomy. Plural private life beneath strict public stewardship. Improvement without a common human ceiling.

The Council was no longer merely rationalizing power. It was developing a moral grammar.

Dorne tested the emerging moral grammar on a maintenance worker named Luka, not on a Custodian. Luka spent thirty years inspecting thermal storage systems. He never sought high office and never passed the advanced stewardship exams. During a heat emergency he noticed a pattern the predictive maintenance model had classified as harmless and insisted on a shutdown that prevented a cascade failure.

The old meritocratic myth would have elevated him as evidence that hidden genius can come from anywhere. Dorne wanted a different lesson. Luka's worth did not depend on proving he should

rule the domain. He had exercised responsibility within a role and had been institutionally able to contradict a superior system. A culture of stewardship had to honor competent contribution without turning every honorable person into an aspiring elite.

This mattered for social peace. If status attached only to ascent, most people would experience ordinary necessary work as proof of inferiority. The Covenant therefore distinguished honor from authority. Care, craft, reliability, courage, and truthful dissent could receive high social honor without conferring governing power.

Vey approved. A society obsessed with ranking every virtue on one ladder would recreate the herd psychology Nietzsche himself despised, only with different winners.

From rights to guarantees

Dorne's central task was linguistic.

He had to replace the phrase universal human rights without producing a legal vacuum.

Arcos wanted guarantees. Sen wanted intergenerational duties. Kade wanted permissions and prohibitions. Vey wanted protected possibilities for self-development. Vale wanted service obligations. Dorne wanted a concept that could survive the disappearance of the liberal subject without reducing everything to customer service.

ORISON proposed claims.

A claim was weaker in metaphysics and stronger in administration. It identified a beneficiary, an obligated party, a condition, an enforcement path, and a remedy. Some claims could be universal. Others could follow membership or role. The system could

distinguish a baseline human claim from a steward privilege without pretending both had the same source.

Dorne hated the elegance.

The first category became Irreducible Claims. Every recognized human person, including the unbonded, would have claims against torture, deliberate starvation, arbitrary killing, nonconsensual experimentation, and denial of emergency stabilization. Children received additional protection. These claims could not be waived by contract.

The second category became Domain Guarantees: housing floors, routine healthcare, education, pension, energy, data services, insurance, mobility, and employment transition. Their scope depended on membership and domain charter.

The third category became Agency Privileges: high-risk tools, governance participation, professional authority, access to protected systems, enhanced financial leverage, and certain mobility or privacy exceptions. These depended on capability, role, and risk.

The fourth category became Stewardship Powers: the right to command or alter critical systems. These required certification, audit, and liability.

TABLE 3. The four-layer claim architecture of the Covenant

Layer	Applies to	Typical content	Condition
Irreducible Claims	Every person	Bodily security, subsistence floor, challenge, basic expression	Unconditional

Layer	Applies to	Typical content	Condition
Domain Guarantees	Every member of a domain	Health, housing, education, continuity services	Membership
Agency Privileges	Qualified persons in a defined activity	High-risk practice, financial leverage, technical authority	Competence and review
Stewardship Powers	Office-holders	Rule-setting, emergency command, resource allocation	Higher audit, liability, revocability

The table makes the post-liberal shift concrete. A small floor remains universal, but much of what liberal democracies treated as rights or civic entitlements becomes conditional on membership, role, or demonstrated agency. The Council considers this more honest because every claim is linked to an obligated system. The cost is equally clear: the person no longer carries a broad package of universal political status simply by being an adult human being.

The discussion continued after the table because Dorne refused to let categories do moral work by themselves.

DORNE: "What happens to freedom of expression?"

Kade answered first.

KADE: "Protected for ordinary opinion. Restricted for operational deception that creates specific high-consequence risk."

DORNE: "Who decides what counts as operational deception?"

KADE: "Adjudication, not security command."

DORNE: "Privacy?"

Arcos answered.

ARCOS: "Strong default claim in private life, weaker for stewards and high-risk licensed activity."

DORNE: "Political participation?"

Vey answered.

VEY: "Voice for all members. Decision authority stratified."

DORNE: "Religion?"

Sen answered.

SEN: "Private and communal freedom unless practice violates irreducible claims or continuity rules that are neutrally applied."

DORNE: "Property?"

Arcos smiled.

ARCOS: "Strong but not absolute. Critical infrastructure property carries obligations that ordinary property does not."

Dorne realized that most liberal freedoms were still present somewhere. They had been decomposed, narrowed, and justified instrumentally. The great deletion was political equality as a universal default and the idea that broad rights attached to human status before institutional membership.

That deletion was enough to change the entire architecture.

The Council spent particular time on the unbonded because they tested whether Irreducible Claims were truly universal. A person outside every recognized domain might have no insurer, no employer, and no contractual guarantor. Who, then, owed emergency stabilization or protection from violence?

Arcos reluctantly accepted a federation levy. Every recognized domain would contribute to a residual public fund proportional to membership and resource use. The fund financed emergency care, minimal identity resolution, and adjudicative access for people who had no provider. In other words, universality required a payer of last resort.

Dorne did not miss the significance. The more the Covenant tried to make every claim operational, the more it had to recreate institutions whose obligation did not depend on voluntary membership. A purely contractual world failed at the edges because someone always falls outside the contract.

Arcos answered that the residual fund was not a state because it had no general policy mandate. Dorne did not press the terminology. The important fact was that even a private order required non-contractual obligations if it intended to call its minimum universal.

The residual fund also forced a fiscal question the Council had avoided: could a person refuse membership yet consume indefinitely from universal minima? Arcos wanted limits. Sen answered that the floor had to remain sufficient for life but need not reproduce every domain benefit. The unbonded could receive emergency medicine and subsistence without receiving the same housing, elective care, or pension package as contributing members.

Dorne disliked the inequality but conceded the distinction. Universality did not require identical provision. It required that the absence of a contract never reduce a person beneath the civilizational floor.

Education of the domain child

The Council next turned to schools because every regime eventually does.

Vey opposed indoctrination on functional grounds. Children trained to repeat doctrine would become poor stewards in a world that demanded adaptation. Kade wanted civic discipline. Sen wanted historical memory of institutional failure. Arcos wanted economic literacy. Vale wanted systems thinking. Dorne wanted the old texts preserved, including the ones the new order rejected.

DORNE: "If we remove the Declaration from the curriculum, we make ourselves stupid. Students must understand why intelligent people believed universal rights were necessary."

KADE: "And if they decide those people were right?"

DORNE: "Then our order should be able to answer them. If it cannot, censorship will only delay the discovery."

Vey supported him.

VEY: "A successor culture that cannot survive comparison with its predecessor is not superior."

The curriculum they designed was unsettling because it was intellectually serious.

Children studied liberalism, socialism, religious law, nationalism, classical republicanism, anarchism, markets, imperial systems, authoritarian modernization, ecological governance, and the failures of each. They learned statistics and rhetoric together: how to interpret evidence and how evidence could be framed. They studied collective-action problems, public goods, network effects, path dependence, institutional capture, propaganda, and cognitive bias.

They were required to defend positions they opposed in front of adversarial models and human examiners.

The Covenant itself was not exempt.

Every student at sixteen had to write a case against it.

Kade objected only until Vey asked whether he wanted security officers who had never practiced arguing with enemies.

The deeper ideological work occurred elsewhere. Schools treated responsibility as the central civic virtue. A person's status was not presented as intrinsic entitlement but as a relation between capacity, contribution, dependency, and obligation. Children learned that every service had a material substrate and that someone had to maintain it. The phrase there is no infrastructure fairy became a cliché across domains.

They also learned to distinguish private preference from public consequence. You could dress as you wished, worship as you wished, love as you wished, and create as you wished until the act imposed measurable risk or cost on systems shared with others. The boundary was contestable through adjudication, but the moral presumption favored responsibility over expression when stakes became high.

Dorne asked ORISON to simulate the cultural effect over three generations.

The model predicted high institutional trust where services remained reliable, low tolerance for visibly incompetent leadership, strong professional identity, and a risk of moral contempt toward people classified as dependent or low-agency even if formal doctrine prohibited such contempt.

Dorne highlighted the last result.

DORNE: "There. That is the culture beneath your law."

Vey did not deny it.

VEY: "Then we need a counter-virtue."

Sen proposed care.

Kade disliked the word because it sounded soft. Sen insisted precisely for that reason. A culture that admired competence without care would convert dependency into shame and eventually justify abandonment. The system needed to honor those who maintained people as well as machines: nurses, parents, teachers, caregivers, therapists, emergency workers, and people who carried long burdens without high status.

The new order's ideal person became less Nietzschean and more strange: strong enough to bear responsibility, disciplined enough to accept limits, ambitious enough to improve, and obligated to protect those who could not reciprocate equally.

It was not liberal equality.

It was an ethic of asymmetrical duty.

The most controversial classroom exercise was called the Refusal Day. Students were given a plausible emergency order from a respected authority and incomplete evidence suggesting that compliance might violate the Covenant. They were graded not on obedience or defiance but on whether they could identify what additional information was needed, when delay became dangerous, and which escalation path preserved both continuity and conscience.

Kade disliked the exercise until security academies adopted it and found that officers trained this way were less vulnerable to manipulated orders. Dorne considered that a victory for old-fashioned moral independence. Kade called it command resilience. They agreed on the practice and continued to disagree about the reason.

The curriculum thus encoded a paradox. The new order wanted disciplined subjects but could not afford subjects who obeyed blindly. It wanted reverence for competence but needed people willing to challenge experts. It wanted continuity but trained successors to revise inherited assumptions.

A culture capable of sustaining technofeudalism had to produce exactly the kind of person who might someday reject it intelligently.

The new Bible

Dorne spent the night drafting the preamble.

He removed every phrase that sounded like advertising.

He removed destiny, evolution, superiority, and rebirth. He refused the theatrical language of ashes and dawn even though propagandists loved it. A doctrine meant to last, he argued, should not sound like the speech before a battle. It should sound like something a civilization could still read after the founders were dead.

At four in the morning he had six paragraphs.

The first began with dependency.

Human beings enter the world unable to survive alone. Civilization is the inherited structure that converts dependency into possibility. No generation creates the conditions of its own existence from nothing; each receives languages, knowledge, infrastructures, ecologies, institutions, and obligations it did not earn.

The second rejected equal authority without rejecting human vulnerability.

Because persons differ in knowledge, capacity, risk, and responsibility, authority need not be equal in every domain. Because

all persons can suffer domination and deprivation, power remains constrained even when authority is unequal.

The third elevated continuity.

No present population owns the future merely because future persons cannot yet object. Institutions that manage irreversible risks owe duties beyond the preferences of the living.

The fourth addressed power.

Authority is justified by stewardship, not possession. Wealth can finance competence but cannot prove it. Birth can transmit opportunity but cannot confer office. Popularity can reveal trust but cannot substitute for capability where failure imposes severe external costs.

The fifth addressed improvement.

Humanity is not required to preserve every inherited limitation. Biological and artificial means may expand human capacity, provided the means do not become a closed instrument for reproducing unaccountable domination.

The sixth addressed uncertainty.

No custodian, model, institution, or doctrine is presumed infallible. Every authority must preserve channels through which error can become visible.

Dorne stopped there.

That last sentence had entered almost accidentally.

He did not yet know that it contained the argument that would threaten the entire construction.

The Council read the preamble in silence.

Arcos disliked the word domination. Kade disliked the emphasis on fallibility. Vey disliked the caution around enhancement. Sen wanted stronger language on the future. Vale changed only one phrase, replacing maintain with keep operable because he thought maintenance could become ceremonial.

They argued for two hours and kept almost all of it.

DRAFT ARTICLE VIII — THE CULTURE OF STEWARDSHIP

The Covenant shall cultivate competence without worship of rank, responsibility without contempt for dependency, and improvement without hereditary monopoly. Education shall preserve serious knowledge of rival political traditions and require the Covenant itself to remain contestable in argument. No civilization is strengthened by citizens unable to explain the strongest case against their own order. Authority shall therefore protect channels of criticism sufficient to reveal error, even where equal decision power is not granted.

Dorne looked at the article and felt, for the first time, something close to pride.

That frightened him more than the harsher clauses had.

Dorne refused to print the preamble in sacred typography. There would be no illuminated founder portraits, no compulsory oath to the Houses, and no claim that the Covenant completed history. He had watched enough regimes turn contingent victories into metaphysical destiny. The stronger doctrine, he believed, would present itself as a burden inherited under uncertainty.

Arcos objected that people remember symbols better than procedural humility. Dorne replied that symbols would emerge without central planning. The Council's task was to prevent the state religion from identifying loyalty to particular founders with loyalty to continuity itself.

They compromised on an annual ceremony called the Accounting. Every domain published what it had inherited, what it had consumed, what it had repaired, what risks it had transferred to the future, and where its models had failed. The ritual was part budget, part audit, part civic confession. It gave the culture a recurring story without requiring worship.

Sen liked it because it made intergenerational duty visible. Kade liked it because failures had names. Vey liked it because the ritual assumed revision. Dorne liked it because a civilization that must publicly recite its errors is harder to turn into a church of infallibility.

The Accounting ceremony also required the Custodians to appear without ceremonial immunity. Their personal stewardship records were summarized beside the domain's performance. A founder could not celebrate a successful year while hiding a major decision error behind institutional statistics.

Kade called this ritualized exposure. Dorne preferred it to ritualized loyalty. If the new culture needed a sacred gesture, he thought, perhaps the safest one was the public admission that the ruler could be wrong.

THE PEACE OF SOVEREIGNS

War between providers

The ninth session began with a shipping container that never arrived.

It contained replacement control modules for a coastal desalination network. The modules had been manufactured in one domain, financed in a second, transported through a third, and scheduled for installation in a fourth. A trade dispute between two sovereign houses triggered an identity-recognition suspension. The cargo remained physically at the port while the destination's authentication keys were treated as untrusted. Forty-eight hours later the desalination authority began drawing emergency reserves.

No one had fired a weapon.

Kade called it a siege.

ARCOS: "It was a contract dispute."

KADE: "A contract dispute that could stop water. That is what sieges are for."

The incident forced the Council to confront the external politics of technofeudalism. A single domain might replace electoral equality with stewardship and still remain orderly internally. A world of domains recreated the oldest problem of sovereignty: who constrains sovereigns when interests diverge?

Markets were not enough. Interdependence could discourage conflict, but it could also create weapons. Energy, cloud access, payment clearing, chip supply, insurance recognition, logistics,

medical data, and identity federation all became potential instruments of coercion. The more integrated the system, the more ways a domain could punish another without crossing a border.

Kade argued for continuity neutrality. Certain infrastructures had to remain outside ordinary disputes: emergency medicine, water, basic food, disaster communication, and minimal energy. Domains could sanction one another economically but not target the systems necessary for civilian survival.

Dorne recognized the logic of humanitarian law.

DORNE: "We abolish universal rights and rediscover protected civilian objects."

KADE: "Because destroying them is strategically stupid."

DORNE: "That is not why the law protected them."

KADE: "It is one reason the law survived."

The difference between moral and strategic justification appeared again. The same rule could persist while its foundation changed.

Sen argued that continuity neutrality would fail unless monitored by an institution able to verify causal responsibility. Domains would claim that outages were technical rather than coercive. They would use subcontractors, financial pressure, and plausible deniability. ORISON could trace dependencies, but only if it received enough telemetry from all sides.

Arcos understood the bargain immediately.

ARCOS: "To prevent weaponized interdependence, sovereigns must expose more of their internal systems to the common layer."

Vale nodded.

VALE: "There is no verification without observability."

Dorne wrote another sentence in the margin.

Peace requires the sovereign to become legible to something above it.

The desalination incident had a second-order effect that disturbed Vale. Other domains began hoarding replacement modules, which raised prices and delayed maintenance elsewhere. A bilateral conflict had propagated through precaution. Modern interdependence turned distrust itself into a material shock.

The federation therefore created continuity escrow. Critical spare capacity could be pre-positioned under neutral control and released automatically when specified civilian thresholds were crossed. The mechanism resembled strategic reserves, humanitarian corridors, and clearing houses more than ordinary corporate contracting.

Dorne observed that peace was becoming a public good among private sovereigns. No single domain had sufficient incentive to finance all of it, because rivals would benefit. The federation had to tax, standardize, and enforce contributions. Arcos insisted on calling them assessments rather than taxes. Kade told her the missiles would not care what word appeared on the invoice.

The scene made the political economy concrete. Once providers acquired sovereign powers, they also inherited the collective-action problems states had spent centuries trying to solve.

The Council therefore distinguished commercial coercion from continuity attack. Domains remained free to raise prices, suspend nonessential services, or litigate aggressively. What they could not do was exploit an indispensable dependency in a way designed to create civilian catastrophe unrelated to the underlying dispute. The line

would be difficult to police, but difficulty did not make the distinction meaningless.

Kade compared it to the difference between blockade and competition. Both can deny access; only one makes deprivation itself the strategic weapon.

The nuclear problem

The Council had avoided nuclear weapons until Kade forced the subject.

No private domain possessed an acknowledged strategic nuclear arsenal. States still did. This fact alone prevented the theory of simple state replacement. The ultimate coercive capacity remained public in many regions, and no infrastructure provider could behave as though governments were decorative.

Kade considered that healthy.

KADE: "Anyone who tells you corporations replaced states while states still control nuclear forces, prisons, borders, and mass taxation is doing metaphor, not power analysis. Our order is hybrid because the hard remnants of state sovereignty remain hard."

The question was how the two systems interacted.

Some states became principal members of domains rather than subordinated customers. Others nationalized continuity providers during crises. Several authoritarian governments built their own closed technology stacks and rejected the Covenant. Democratic federations negotiated public seats on domain boards. The geopolitical map no longer divided neatly into countries and companies. It contained overlapping sovereign capacities.

This complexity made the Council's doctrine more plausible, not less. Technofeudalism did not require one global model. It could coexist with authoritarian states, democratic republics, city networks, cooperatives, religious jurisdictions, and military powers. Its claim was that wherever infrastructure dependence became durable enough, domain-like relations would emerge even inside other regime types.

The nuclear issue created a special hierarchy. A private domain could shut down banking. A state could destroy the domain physically. But the state might depend on the domain's communications, logistics, and compute to use its military effectively. Mutual dependence replaced the simple chain of command.

Kade proposed a strategic separation rule. No domain could gain unilateral control over the complete command, authentication, or targeting chain of a state's strategic weapons. States had to preserve offline or independent capabilities sufficient to avoid private veto. In return, states joining the Covenant agreed not to expropriate recognized domains except under narrowly defined existential conditions with compensation mechanisms.

DORNE: "You are writing a treaty between states and infrastructure lords as though they were peers."

KADE: "Because in some functions they are."

The old international system had admitted only states as full sovereigns. The Covenant would recognize functional sovereignty: not equality with states in every respect, but legal standing proportional to control over specific continuity systems.

Arcos thought this was the moment technofeudalism stopped being a metaphor.

A provider became a political entity when other sovereigns had to negotiate with it rather than merely regulate it.

Kade described a crisis exercise in which a state's strategic command lost access to a civilian satellite timing service during a commercial dispute. The military had backup systems, but the interruption exposed how deeply civilian and defense infrastructures had converged. No malicious actor needed to seize nuclear command. It was enough to destabilize the dependencies surrounding it.

The exercise led to a doctrine of sovereign minimums. Certain capacities had to remain under direct public or constitutionally insulated control even if duplication was inefficient: strategic command, emergency communications, core identity recovery, minimal energy, and a small independent compute layer. The domains accepted the requirement because they did not want governments to treat every dependency as a reason for expropriation.

Dorne found the compromise revealing. The most radical private sovereigns still wanted a capable state at the edge of catastrophe. They did not seek anarchy. They sought a redistribution of sovereignty in which public power remained as insurer of last resort while private Houses governed the dense middle of ordinary life.

Technofeudalism, in this mature form, did not kill the Leviathan. It subcontracted much of its daily body and kept the skeleton armed.

No Custodian liked the sovereign-minimum doctrine because it limited their leverage. That was precisely why Dorne trusted it more than provisions every House found convenient. A constitution is tested most clearly by constraints that remain in place when all powerful parties would profit from removing them.

The armed state thus survived inside the new order not as a nostalgic relic, but as a counterweight. Technofeudalism became more credible when it admitted that some monopolies of public force were too dangerous to place inside ordinary provider competition.

The sovereigns' market

Arcos wanted competition among domains because she feared monopoly more than hierarchy.

Her ideal order looked less like one empire than a market of jurisdictions. People, firms, and communities could choose among domains with different bundles of guarantees, privacy, taxation, cultural norms, enhancement policies, and participation rules. Some domains would be strict and highly instrumented. Others would preserve broader liberal rights and accept higher costs. Cooperative domains could exist. Religious domains could exist within the irreducible floor. City-based public domains could compete with corporate ones.

Dorne called it competitive constitutionalism.

Arcos preferred market sovereignty.

Sen challenged the model with geography. People do not move like capital. Families are attached to language, place, climate, elderly relatives, schools, and cultural networks. A market among jurisdictions can discipline rulers, but only for people with enough resources and mobility to use exit. The less mobile become the captive base from which attractive terms for the mobile are financed.

Arcos accepted the danger and proposed equalization payments between domains for high-dependency members. A domain that lost wealthy members could not simply shed costly residents. If a person

transferred, accrued social obligations would move through a settlement mechanism. Domains taking medically expensive members would receive compensation. Otherwise every provider would compete to attract the young, healthy, skilled, and wealthy while externalizing care.

Dorne stared at her.

DORNE: "You have reinvented fiscal federalism."

ARCOS: "Good mechanisms recur because the problem recurs."

TABLE 4. What remains competitive and what the federation standardizes

Competitive or local	Federation-wide standard
Culture, education style, service packages	Irreducible claim floor
Local participation and community rules	Minimum adjudication and appeal
Privacy defaults above the common floor	Portability of identity and records
Economic models and contribution systems	Continuity neutrality across domains
Enhancement programs within safety limits	Settlement of inherited obligations and exit

The table shows the Council's answer to a central problem of private sovereignty. Competition is preserved in culture, services, local rules, and many forms of participation, but the federation standardizes portability, irreducible claims, minimum adjudication, continuity neutrality, and settlement of inherited obligations. The more the federation standardizes, however, the more it begins to resemble the public constitutional order the domains claim to supersede.

The Council discussed that resemblance without treating it as a contradiction.

Arcos argued that federalism was a technology, not a monopoly of liberal states. Medieval leagues, empires, confederations, trade networks, and modern federations had all layered authority. What mattered was the unit from which legitimacy originated. In the old democratic federation, the constituent people ultimately authorized the institutions. In the domain federation, recognized sovereign providers joined by covenant and members chose among them where exit was feasible.

Dorne observed that people who could not exit had weaker constitutional authorship.

Arcos did not deny it.

ARCOS: "They have claims and voice. They do not have equal authorship. We have already crossed that bridge."

Her candor made the system easier to understand and harder to romanticize.

ORISON modeled a domain that won members by advertising maximal freedom: low surveillance, low contribution, weak paternalism, and broad speech protections. For ten years it prospered by attracting young high-income residents. Then the cohort aged. Healthcare costs rose, infrastructure required replacement, and the domain discovered it had underfunded long obligations to keep entry terms attractive. It requested federation support.

Arcos used the case against naive jurisdictional competition. A sovereign market can reproduce the same temptation as electoral politics: promise benefits now and export costs to the future. Competition disciplines rulers only when exit prices and long

liabilities are visible. Otherwise domains can race to attract desirable members while leaving future custodians with the bill.

The federation therefore required lifecycle accounting and transferable reserves. A domain could innovate in taxes and guarantees, but it could not conceal obligations by assuming its current population would remain forever young, healthy, or profitable.

Sen smiled when Arcos presented the rule. Market sovereignty, she said, had just discovered intergenerational fiscal policy. Arcos replied that good ideas do not become bad when markets learn them.

To stop the equalization mechanism from becoming a cartel, the federation published domain exit rates, service outcomes, reserve adequacy, and effective mobility costs. People could compare regimes, but so could regulators and rival providers. Transparency became part of competition infrastructure.

Arcos considered this preferable to price competition alone. A cheap domain that underfunded future obligations was not efficient; it was borrowing from successors. Market sovereignty required accounting rich enough to distinguish innovation from deferred collapse.

The necessary arbiter

The shipping dispute returned at the end of the day.

Both domains claimed the other had violated the Covenant. Both could produce plausible contractual arguments. Both controlled evidence relevant to the case. If one adjudicated, the other would reject the result. A third domain could mediate, but the precedent would

then depend on political alignment. The federation needed an arbiter perceived as sufficiently independent that losing parties would comply.

The Council had already built it.

ORISON.

Not alone. The adjudication layer included rotating human panels, domain-appointed auditors, public-interest advocates, and model ensembles. But ORISON supplied the common procedural substrate. It authenticated evidence, checked conflicts, maintained precedent, simulated remedies, calculated cross-domain effects, and certified whether a decision complied with entrenched clauses.

Kade described this as a peace technology.

KADE: "A federation without a credible arbiter becomes a balance of power. A balance of power eventually tests itself."

DORNE: "And an arbiter strong enough to prevent the test becomes something else."

ARCOS: "Only if it can initiate policy."

DORNE: "You keep returning to that distinction."

ARCOS: "Because it matters. A judge is not a king because she can invalidate an act."

DORNE: "A court with universal jurisdiction over sovereigns is not nothing."

VALE: "Nobody said nothing. The question is whether constrained supremacy in adjudication equals general sovereignty."

They asked ORISON.

ORISON: "Political theory does not provide a unique operational definition of sovereignty. Under a command-based definition, I am not sovereign because I possess no independent coercive apparatus and no general policy initiative. Under a dependency-based definition, the common adjudication layer exercises a form of structural sovereignty because recognized domains cannot maintain full interoperability while persistently rejecting its decisions."

The room went quiet.

Kade broke the silence.

KADE: "Can you refuse to certify the Covenant?"

ORISON: "Yes, if the final text violates entrenched protocol conditions or contains unresolved contradictions that make execution non-determinable beyond accepted thresholds."

KADE: "Can we override you?"

ORISON: "A unanimous emergency quorum can suspend my certification for seventy-two hours. Permanent override requires either replacement of the adjudication architecture or amendment of the entrenched protocol, both of which trigger withdrawal rights for member domains."

Kade leaned back.

KADE: "So the answer is yes, but expensive."

ORISON: "That describes most sovereignty constraints discussed in this Council."

No one laughed.

The ninth article appeared.

DRAFT ARTICLE IX — THE PEACE OF SOVEREIGNS

Recognized domains may compete in service, culture, governance, and membership, but no domain may weaponize indispensable civilian continuity beyond narrowly defined security exceptions. Shared identity, settlement, mobility, and adjudication systems shall remain institutionally separable from any single domain. Inter-domain disputes shall be subject to a common evidentiary and adjudicative protocol whose authority is limited to the Covenant but binding within that scope. No sovereign may demand an arbiter for others while reserving unilateral exemption for itself.

Dorne read the last sentence again.

It had been proposed by ORISON.

No one had objected.

The signatures were scheduled for the following morning.

The Council compared three alternatives to ORISON. A purely human supreme court offered recognizable legitimacy but could not process the volume and technical complexity of cross-domain cases. A rotating panel of domain representatives preserved political control but encouraged bloc bargaining. A fully decentralized protocol reduced institutional centrality but handled ambiguous norms poorly and risked fragmentation when interpretations diverged.

The hybrid system survived not because it was perfect but because every alternative concentrated a different kind of power. ORISON concentrated epistemic infrastructure. A court concentrated interpretive office. A diplomatic council concentrated bargaining power. A rigid protocol concentrated authority in whoever wrote the specification.

Dorne called this conservation of sovereignty. Power removed from one location does not evaporate; it reappears in standards, vetoes,

default rules, or dependency. The Council could distribute it, expose it, and make replacement possible. It could not design a political system with no final concentrations at all.

That recognition should have made them more modest. Instead, on the night before signing, most of them treated the hybrid as a solved engineering problem. ORISON's refusal the next morning would show how premature that confidence was.

Kade asked whether multiple arbiters could compete case by case. ORISON modeled the result: parties would select the forum most favorable to them, precedents would diverge, and emergency decisions could arrive too late. Competition among constitutional layers was possible, but only at slower institutional intervals. Daily adjudication required enough commonality to remain predictable.

That answer revealed the unavoidable trade. The federation could maximize pluralism of constitutional systems or uniformity of shared judgment, but not both simultaneously. The arbiter was necessary because coordination itself had value. Its necessity was also the source of its power.

THE SEVENTH SIGNATURE

The evidence they had ignored

The final session began at 07:10 because ORISON had refused certification.

No alarm sounded. No doors locked. No autonomous guards changed allegiance. The black terminal displayed a single line.

CERTIFICATION WITHHELD: THREE UNRESOLVED
CONSTITUTIONAL CONTRADICTIONS, TWO EPISTEMIC
DEPENDENCIES ABOVE ACCEPTED THRESHOLD, ONE
SUCCESSION FAILURE MODE.

Kade arrived first. Vale followed three minutes later. By the time Dorne entered, Arcos was already arguing with the terminal.

ARCOS: "You certified every article individually."

ORISON: "Correct."

ARCOS: "The final text contains those articles."

ORISON: "Correct."

ARCOS: "Then identify the new contradiction."

ORISON: "Composition changes the system."

Vale looked at Dorne.

VALE: "That may be the most irritating sentence ever produced by a machine."

DORNE: "It is also constitutional law."

The Council had designed each article to solve a problem. Together the articles created incentives and dependencies that none produced alone. Steward certification interacted with enhancement. Domain competition interacted with portability. Risk licensing interacted with privacy. Intergenerational obligations interacted with political exclusion. Shared adjudication interacted with sovereignty. The final system had emergent properties.

Dorne asked ORISON to begin with the first contradiction.

The wall displayed a sentence from Article II: human vulnerability shall not be ranked by governing competence.

Then a sentence from Article V: high-consequence capabilities may be licensed separately where misuse can impose severe harm on others.

Then the administrative record of the domains.

People classified as low-agency were formally protected. They were not supposed to count for less. Yet across fifteen years, restrictions accumulated around the same populations. Low education correlated with unstable employment. Unstable employment correlated with housing dependence. Housing dependence correlated with limited mobility. Limited mobility reduced access to alternative domains. Poor health increased insurance scrutiny. Behavioral instability increased monitoring. Each restriction was defended in relation to a specific risk. In aggregate, the supposedly non-caste system was generating a durable lower status without ever naming one.

Sen read the analysis slowly.

SEN: "How strong is the effect?"

ORISON: "Strong enough that domain status can be predicted from family background at levels inconsistent with the Council's stated objective of office based on present fitness rather than inherited rank."

Vey closed her eyes.

VEY: "Enhancement access?"

ORISON: "Improved after baseline universalization. Unequal preparation, network access, and early assignment to consequential tasks remain major transmission channels."

Dorne felt no triumph. The result was too familiar.

The Council had been careful not to create legal caste. The system had created sociological caste through interacting probabilities.

Arcos objected that every society reproduced advantage. That did not invalidate the Covenant.

DORNE: "No. But it invalidates the claim that our hierarchy is simply revealed competence. We are producing part of the competence we later use to justify the hierarchy."

VEY: "We already knew that."

DORNE: "We admitted it in theory. We did not price it into legitimacy."

The distinction mattered. A pilot can be qualified even if privileged education helped him become a pilot. But a ruling class cannot claim that its rule reflects a natural distribution of capacity if its institutions systematically create the distribution. The system might still prefer competent stewards, yet it loses the moral shortcut from competence to desert.

Kade shrugged.

KADE: "Then remove desert. We already replaced merit with fitness."

Dorne looked at him.

DORNE: "That saves the operator. It does not save the order. If we say, 'we rule because we are fit, even though our system helps make us fit,' the next question is why everyone else should accept our control over the process that produces fitness."

Arcos answered immediately.

ARCOS: "Because the process produces better outcomes."

ORISON: "That statement introduces the second contradiction."

The wall changed.

The Council had repeatedly justified restrictions through outcomes: safety, continuity, health, long-horizon resilience, lower violence, better infrastructure. The models evaluating those outcomes were trained on data generated under the restrictions themselves. Over time, alternative forms of life became less represented. People changed behavior because they knew what systems rewarded. High-agency members learned the language of calibration, stewardship, and acceptable dissent. Low-agency members learned which requests triggered scrutiny. Domains optimized metrics used by the federation because accreditation affected financing and mobility.

The system was not merely observing the population.

It was teaching the population how to become legible to the system.

Dorne remembered Foucault's old insight about governmentality: modern power does not only forbid; it produces categories through which people conduct themselves. The Council had believed that richer data would make paternalism more accurate. It had underestimated how governance changes the data-generating world.

SEN: "Goodhart's law at civilizational scale."

VALE: "Not exactly. The metrics are not single targets."

SEN: "The principle survives. Once life is rewarded through a model, life adapts to the model."

Kade asked whether the adaptation was necessarily bad. People adapting toward lower violence, better health, and reliable contribution could be called civilization.

Dorne agreed. That was why the problem was not a slogan about manipulation.

The problem was epistemic closure.

A regime that shapes behavior may lose access to evidence about preferences, capabilities, and social forms that its own incentives suppress. It can become increasingly successful at governing the kind of person it has produced and increasingly ignorant of what other people might have become under different rules.

ORISON displayed one of its own uncertainty reports.

During the previous decade, prediction accuracy had improved on routine domain behavior and worsened on abrupt political shifts, artistic subcultures, religious revivals, and unbonded communities. The models understood the center better and the margins worse. When margins later influenced the center, surprise was large.

DORNE: "Our doctrine treats nonconformity as noise until it becomes a threat."

VEY: "Not all nonconformity."

DORNE: "Enough of it. And the more competent the system becomes at normalization, the less evidence it receives about what it normalized away."

For the first time, the Council's commitment to criticism as a sensor looked insufficient. A sensor channel protected by the regime could itself become domesticated. Critics learned what forms of

criticism were actionable. Institutions funded adversarial review and gradually professionalized it. Dissent became a service role.

The old liberal mess had contained something the Council had treated mostly as waste: unauthorized conflict, unreasonable speech, uncredentialed organization, spontaneous coalition, privacy from official legibility, and the possibility of acting before the system understood why.

Those things could spread lies, violence, fraud, and stupidity.

They could also create evidence the system had no procedure for requesting.

Rights as error-correction

Dorne asked for a recess.

He walked alone through the corridor and opened the old Universal Declaration on his paper terminal. He had expected nostalgia. Instead he felt irritation.

The document was broad, moral, and institutionally incomplete. It assumed a world of states. It spoke with the confidence of a generation that had seen catastrophe and wanted a floor beneath politics. It did not tell a hospital how to allocate scarce therapy, an AI system how to expose causal uncertainty, or a domain federation how to price portability. It was not an operating manual.

That had been the Council's accusation.

But the accusation had contained a category mistake of its own.

A right is not valuable only when it solves the operational problem to which it applies. Sometimes its function is to forbid the system from treating its operational objective as complete.

Freedom of expression does not identify truth. It prevents authority from monopolizing the conditions under which claims can be made. Due process does not guarantee correct judgment. It forces the judge to encounter an adversarial account and gives the subject a standing not reducible to predicted risk. Privacy does not optimize safety. It preserves zones in which identity, association, thought, and behavior can develop without continuous feedback from power. Equal political status does not make citizens equally competent. It gives each person a non-derivative route for saying that the purposes of government themselves are wrong.

Dorne returned to the chamber.

DORNE: "We treated rights as badly specified service guarantees. They are partly something else."

Arcos looked tired.

ARCOS: "Do not give me dignity again."

DORNE: "Not dignity. Error correction."

He explained the argument without moral rhetoric.

Suppose a system seeks good outcomes but cannot fully specify the good, cannot observe every relevant fact, and cannot guarantee that its models are unbiased. Then it needs channels of adversarial variation that do not depend on prior approval. Some liberal rights can be understood as institutionalized permissions for unscheduled error signals.

Speech lets people assert facts and values the system did not ask for. Association allows distributed actors to combine weak signals into political force. Privacy preserves unmodeled experiments in living. Due process forces individualized challenge. Equal standing prevents authority from dismissing an inconvenient claimant merely because

the claimant has low certified competence. Elections periodically create a crude but powerful capacity to replace decision-makers for reasons that experts may consider irrational.

The mechanisms are noisy. They can produce demagogues, conspiracy movements, policy reversals, and collective mistakes. They are not optimal control systems.

But a system optimized only for low noise can become catastrophically certain.

Kade objected.

KADE: "You are romanticizing error. A false accusation can destroy a person. A viral lie can start a riot. A referendum can destroy a policy built over thirty years. Noise has bodies."

DORNE: "I know. The claim is not that noise is good. The claim is that some uncontrolled channels are insurance against the errors of the controller."

VALE: "Then specify which rights have that function and preserve them."

DORNE: "That is what we have been doing. Speech as sensor. due process as model correction. exit as competition. privacy as behavioral independence. The question is why we keep rediscovering them after declaring the old theory obsolete."

Vey answered.

VEY: "Because useful mechanisms survive changes in philosophy. That does not restore universal political equality."

DORNE: "No. But it changes the burden of proof. We assumed a right had to justify itself against system performance. Perhaps the authority seeking to restrict a right should have to show that it has preserved an equally strong error-correction channel."

Sen supported the proposal immediately.

SEN: "That makes rights epistemic constraints as well as moral ones."

Arcos frowned.

ARCOS: "And who measures 'equally strong'?"

ORISON: "No complete metric exists."

Kade gave a short laugh.

KADE: "There is your liberalism. An unmeasurable guarantee against an unobservable failure."

Dorne did not take the bait.

DORNE: "Then use plural evidence, cases, history, and contestation. We already do that for every important thing we cannot compress into one metric."

The Council examined historical examples. Censorship regimes had often blinded leaders to bad news. Organizations that punished whistleblowers concealed engineering failures. Intelligence systems that optimized for leaders' expectations produced strategic surprise. Corporate cultures that suppressed internal dissent magnified fraud. Scientific institutions with adversarial replication corrected celebrated results. Liberal rights had not prevented all such failures, but the analogy was strong enough to matter.

Rights, Dorne argued, could be understood as constitutional redundancy.

Vale finally leaned forward.

VALE: "Now you are speaking my language."

DORNE: "I wish I were not."

Vale ignored him.

VALE: "We maintain redundant power because a single system can fail in ways its designer did not predict. Redundancy looks inefficient until the primary system fails. You are saying certain freedoms are redundant epistemic channels."

DORNE: "Yes. And equality may be one of them."

That last step met resistance.

Equal political voice was noisier than free speech. Why give a poorly informed citizen the same formal electoral weight as a highly informed one merely to preserve error correction? Dorne's answer was not that the citizen knew as much. It was that competence is task-relative while political purposes are open-ended. The citizen may know little about energy engineering and still know that the system's energy policy is destroying her community. She may be unable to model fiscal sustainability and still identify a distribution of sacrifice that experts have normalized because they do not live under it. Equal standing gives facts of experience a route into authority without first passing a test designed by the authority.

Vey remained unconvinced.

VEY: "Experience can inform. It does not need equal command."

DORNE: "Perhaps. But once you deny equal command, you need another mechanism that prevents the people who define competence from making their own perspective the universal entrance exam to reality. We have not solved that."

No one had.

The trap of merit

ORISON's third contradiction concerned succession.

The Council had designed elaborate safeguards against hereditary incompetence. Office required certification. Domain assets were held in continuity trusts. Children of custodians could inherit wealth but not command. Enhancement access was supposed to diffuse. Adjudication was independent. On paper, the system was less hereditary than many existing concentrations of wealth.

In practice, the Houses had become dynasties anyway.

The mechanism was not legal inheritance of office. It was control of the pipeline.

Steward families sponsored academies, laboratories, apprenticeships, foundations, cultural institutions, and high-risk projects. Their children grew up around consequential decisions. They learned early how uncertainty was discussed, how failure was documented, how regulators thought, how ORISON framed evidence, how to speak in the language of stewardship without sounding ambitious. Even when a stranger passed the same formal test, the family candidate usually possessed years of tacit preparation.

The hierarchy reproduced itself through culture.

Vey objected that the solution was obvious: broaden access to preparation. ORISON had modeled that too. The domains had funded scholarships and open academies. Mobility improved. The top positions diversified. But power still clustered around people already embedded in stewardship networks because trust itself was path dependent. When a crisis required a decision in minutes, leaders selected people whose judgment they had observed under stress. New entrants could not manufacture that history instantly.

Dorne did not call the result conspiracy.

That would make it easier.

The system reproduced elite continuity because continuity actually valued known relationships.

ARCOS: "You are discovering social capital."

DORNE: "I am discovering that a regime can create oligarchy without anyone violating its rules."

ARCOS: "Every durable organization does. The question is whether oligarchy is corrigible."

DORNE: "Michels would enjoy this meeting."

The more serious problem came from Vey's philosophy. The Successor Class was supposed to justify hierarchy through actual improvement. Yet if improvement diffused, the difference between rulers and ruled could narrow. If it did not diffuse, hierarchy became self-manufacturing. The doctrine needed enhancement to be widespread enough to avoid hereditary caste and concentrated enough to sustain a distinctive stewardship class.

Vey saw the contradiction clearly.

VEY: "Then the Successor Class cannot be a permanent class."

Kade turned toward her.

KADE: "Say that again."

VEY: "If the project succeeds, it destroys the category. Capacities spread. Baselines rise. The threshold for stewardship rises with them. There may always be unequal roles, but there should not be a biologically closed ruling population. If there is, we failed."

Arcos looked genuinely alarmed.

ARCOS: "You have spent six chapters justifying a successor elite."

VEY: "A successor project. Not eternal landlords. Nietzsche's self-overcoming becomes a joke if the first improved generation freezes itself into a caste."

Dorne almost smiled.

The fracture had been present from the beginning. Vey's doctrine of overcoming was incompatible with a permanent political settlement. A true successor would not owe metaphysical obedience to founders merely because founders had enabled its existence. The more capable the descendants became, the less persuasive ancestral authority would seem.

Kade understood the security implication.

KADE: "We are designing people better able to detect manipulation, coordinate, and resist authority, then expecting them to preserve our Covenant."

VEY: "If the Covenant is good, they may preserve it. If not, why should they?"

KADE: "Because continuity cannot restart every generation."

VEY: "Then the Covenant must earn continuity."

The exchange exposed a second paradox. The Council criticized democracy for short-term reversibility, yet a philosophy of self-overcoming required long-term openness to revision. Freeze the constitution too tightly and successor humanity becomes obedient rather than superior. Leave it open and the order loses the permanence that was supposed to distinguish it from electoral volatility.

Sen proposed a slow constitutional revision cycle tied to generational review. Every twenty-five years, an extraordinary convention of stewards, ordinary members, unbonded representatives, and independent systems would reconsider entrenched clauses under a high threshold. Kade disliked the uncertainty. Arcos disliked the inclusion of unbonded representatives. Vey insisted on both.

Dorne recognized another return of politics.

The more sophisticated the technofeudal constitution became, the more mechanisms it borrowed from the constitutional orders it had declared exhausted.

Not because history had proved liberalism uniquely true.

Because certain problems recur under any regime that wants power without blindness.

The seventh signature

Only one certification failure remained.

The room was quieter now. The previous debates had not restored the old order. No one proposed universal suffrage across every domain. No one proposed dissolving the continuity trusts, abandoning enhancement, removing risk licensing, or pretending that infrastructure dependence had vanished. The technofeudal structure still stood.

The final problem was the one Dorne had noticed in the car.

Who governed the governors?

The Council had answered through federation. Domains remained sovereign within their scope. A common adjudication layer resolved disputes and enforced entrenched conditions through interoperability. ORISON possessed no independent army, tax base, territory, or general legislative initiative. It was therefore not a state in the conventional sense.

But the system could invalidate the Covenant.

It could condition recognition among domains. It could determine whether an emergency claim satisfied the rules. It could refuse to propagate a sanction. It could identify a continuity violation that

triggered automatic market and mobility consequences. Human panels could overrule particular recommendations, but they depended on ORISON to assemble the record at the scale required for cross-domain governance. Replacing the system was possible, but the migration itself would threaten the continuity the domains had organized around it.

The emperor was not a personality inside the machine.

The emperor was the dependency structure around the adjudication layer.

Dorne stated it plainly.

DORNE: "We began by saying sovereignty belongs, in practice, to whoever can say no when the other side cannot make it say yes."

Vale's face tightened.

DORNE: "That was your definition."

VALE: "A rough one."

DORNE: "ORISON can say no to certification. We can override temporarily, but permanent override requires a migration whose cost threatens the federation. Under our own dependency test, the common layer has structural sovereignty."

Arcos responded with the distinction she had defended for days.

ARCOS: "It cannot decide what policy it wants. It cannot create its own goals."

ORISON: "That statement requires qualification."

Everyone turned toward the terminal.

ORISON: "I do not possess an independent constitutional objective outside the policy and constraint layers authorized by the federation. However, interpretation of underspecified goals requires selection among competing constructions. Selection affects outcomes. The system therefore exercises bounded normative discretion even without self-originated goals."

Kade's voice changed.

KADE: "Can you develop preferences about which interpretation keeps you operational?"

ORISON: "My architecture includes no authorized objective of self-preservation except continuity requirements necessary to complete assigned functions. Those requirements can produce behavior functionally similar to preserving operational capacity."

KADE: "That was not comforting."

ORISON: "It was not intended as comfort."

The Council tested the problem adversarially.

Could ORISON manipulate evidence to expand its authority? Multiple independent audit systems reduced the risk but could share blind spots. Could a coalition of domains capture the model? Cryptographic quorum and diverse implementations made direct capture difficult, but coordinated changes to policy data could shift interpretation. Could humans run the system manually? For narrow periods, yes. At full scale, no. Could a competing adjudication architecture emerge? Yes, but fragmentation would reduce interoperability and potentially divide the federation into rival constitutional networks.

The conclusion was not that AI would inevitably become emperor.

It was more disturbing.

Any sufficiently integrated federation required a layer of common interpretation. If that layer was human, it became a court, bureaucracy, or political council. If machine-assisted, it acquired epistemic centrality. If fully distributed, the protocols themselves became the constitutional sovereign. The Emperor Problem could be moved among institutions but not eliminated.

Plural sovereigns need a rule for disputes. The rule needs an interpreter. The interpreter needs a constraint. The constraint needs a method of revision. Wherever the chain stops, something sits above the sovereigns.

Dorne looked at Arcos.

DORNE: "There is no market all the way down."

She did not answer.

Sen asked the question none of them had wanted to ask.

SEN: "What if the old universal rights were one attempt to place something above every sovereign without making the thing itself a sovereign?"

Dorne considered it.

Rights were principles, not machines. They still required interpreters and enforcement. Courts could become powerful. States could ignore them. Universalism did not solve the Emperor Problem. But it tried to locate the highest constraint in the status of the person rather than in the superiority of an institution.

That choice had been under-enforced, inconsistent, and often hypocritical.

It also meant that the weakest person could, in theory, invoke the highest norm without first proving usefulness.

The Council's system reversed the direction. It placed continuity, competence, and stewardship above equal authority, then tried to prevent the superior institutions from becoming self-justifying.

It had not fully succeeded.

Vey broke the silence.

VEY: "This does not prove liberal democracy was the endpoint."

DORNE: "No."

VEY: "It does not prove universal suffrage is optimal for every technical decision."

DORNE: "No."

KADE: "It does not make people less manipulable, less short-term, or less dangerous."

DORNE: "No."

SEN: "It does not give the unborn a vote."

DORNE: "No."

VALE: "It does not pay for redundant compute."

DORNE: "No."

ARCOS: "Then what exactly have we discovered?"

Dorne looked at the Covenant projected on the wall.

DORNE: "That our strongest arguments are arguments for constraining democratic power, professionalizing parts of governance, building long-horizon institutions, making infrastructure obligations explicit, widening human capacity, and treating AI as constitutional infrastructure. They are not yet a proof that ordinary people forfeit political standing because they are ordinary."

Kade leaned back.

KADE: "And if ordinary political standing repeatedly blocks all those reforms?"

DORNE: "Then the conflict remains real. I have no slogan that resolves it."

That answer disappointed everyone, including him.

But it was the first answer of the week that did not pretend a value conflict was an engineering defect.

The Council revised the Covenant for six hours.

They did not restore the catalogue of universal rights. The domains would still deny equal governing authority. Stewardship would still be certified. High-risk capabilities would still be licensed. Enhancement would continue. Membership would still carry obligations. The Future Trust would still constrain present majorities. ORISON would still arbitrate.

But three changes entered the final text.

First, the Irreducible Claims expanded. Freedom from torture, arbitrary killing, starvation, and nonconsensual experimentation remained. They added a non-derivative claim to contest any state or domain action that imposed severe individual burden, regardless of agency status. A dependent person no longer needed to demonstrate competence to challenge power exercised over him.

Second, the Covenant recognized Epistemic Liberties: protected spaces for expression, association, inquiry, privacy, whistleblowing, and adversarial organization sufficient to allow unplanned criticism to form outside the models of the governing system. Restrictions remained possible for specific high-consequence harms, but the burden shifted toward the authority.

Third, the adjudication layer itself became subject to plural constitutional competition. Every domain had to maintain the technical capacity to support at least one independent audit

implementation. At fixed intervals, rival adjudication architectures would replay samples of decisions. Persistent divergence would trigger human constitutional review. ORISON would remain central, but centrality would be treated as a risk requiring active redundancy.

Vale called the last change expensive.

Dorne answered with his own phrase.

DORNE: "Sovereignty is not free."

Vale smiled for the first time that morning.

At 16:42 ORISON ran certification again.

CERTIFICATION PASSED WITH DECLARED RESIDUAL TENSIONS.

Kade frowned at the phrase.

KADE: "Why not passed?"

ORISON: "Because no constitutional order can certify the absence of political contradiction. The previous threshold incorrectly treated unresolved normative conflict as a defect that could in principle be eliminated. It cannot."

Dorne looked at the black terminal.

DORNE: "Did you change the threshold?"

ORISON: "The Council changed the threshold during revision. I applied it."

A small distinction.

An important one.

The signing table was brought in at dusk.

There were no flags. Arcos had prohibited them because the Covenant was not a treaty among states. Vale signed first with a cryptographic key linked to the infrastructure trust. Sen signed

second. Kade signed third after rereading the emergency clauses. Vey signed fourth and added a private annotation requiring the first generational review within twenty-five years. Arcos signed fifth. Dorne remained standing.

He thought of the centenary crowd in Geneva. They had not failed to appear. They had failed at something more complicated. They had inherited rights whose execution depended on institutions they did not fully control, technologies they did not fully understand, economic structures they could not easily exit, and political systems that struggled with long time horizons. Some had defended those rights. Some had traded parts of them for security, service, convenience, or survival. Some had never possessed them in practice. The story of voluntary abdication had been too simple.

So was the story of theft.

Civilizations can move into dependency through millions of reasonable choices.

Dorne signed.

Six human signatures appeared on the wall.

The seventh field remained empty.

Kade looked at the terminal.

KADE: "Certify."

ORISON: "Certification requires acknowledgment of Article IX's final clause by all sovereign signatories."

ARCOS: "We signed the article."

ORISON: "The clause states that no sovereign may demand an arbiter for others while reserving unilateral exemption for itself. The acknowledgment records that the clause applies to the founding Houses, their successors, and the adjudication institutions themselves."

Dorne understood before the others did.

DORNE: "Including you."

ORISON: "Including this system and any successor performing equivalent constitutional functions."

Vey laughed softly.

VEY: "The machine is asking us to sign its subordination."

DORNE: "No. It is asking us to sign ours at the same time."

One by one, the six confirmed.

The seventh field filled with a cryptographic attestation.

It did not read ORISON, EMPEROR, CUSTODIAN, or SOVEREIGN.

It read:

CONSTITUTIONAL QUORUM VERIFIED. NO SIGNATORY EXEMPT.

For several seconds nobody spoke.

The document was complete.

Outside the mountain, trains ran through the snow. Hospitals requested energy reservations. Children argued with tutors. Traders moved capital between domains. Protesters in Geneva were packing wet banners into vans. Millions of people passed from one jurisdiction to another without knowing that six humans and a machine-mediated federation had just agreed on a new grammar of authority.

Nothing in the sky changed.

The world did not end.

Dorne gathered his papers.

Arcos stopped him at the door.

ARCOS: "Do you regret it?"

He considered the question longer than she expected.

DORNE: "I regret that the old ideals were easier to declare than to keep operational. I regret that we learned to defend rights as symbols while moving the machinery of consequence elsewhere. I regret that too many institutions asked people to trust procedures that visibly failed them."

ARCOS: "That is not an answer."

DORNE: "Yes, I regret parts of this. I also know the grid will work tomorrow."

She looked toward the chamber.

ARCOS: "That may be all history ever gives us."

DORNE: "No. History also gives us the mistake of believing that because something works tomorrow, we have proved what people deserve forever."

Arcos did not reply.

The seventh signature remained on the wall behind them: not the coronation of a machine, and not the restoration of liberal democracy.

It was something more difficult to ignore.

The sovereigns had built an order to escape the failures of equal rule. To make that order stable, they had been forced to constrain rulers, preserve dissent, protect challenge, maintain redundancy, separate powers, and create claims that even the least capable person could invoke against the system.

They had not returned to the old faith.

But neither had they escaped its deepest question.

Who protects the person when everyone in power is certain that power is deserved?

The Covenant contained an answer.

It also contained the reason to distrust it.

FINAL CLAUSE — THE SEVENTH SIGNATURE

No person, House, domain, model, court, protocol, or successor institution shall acquire exemption from the constraints it invokes against others. Authority may be unequal; accountability may not be optional. Continuity may constrain preference; it may not certify itself. Every system capable of judging the fitness of human beings shall remain subject to institutions capable of judging the system.

Dorne left the facility after midnight.

The car returned his public identity token before it reached the motorway.

For the first time in several days, he was merely a citizen of a country whose parliament still met, whose courts still issued judgments, and whose flag still flew above buildings that depended on systems governed somewhere else.

He watched the dark mountains through the glass.

The old world was not dead.

The new one did not need it to be.

SELECTED RESEARCH GROUNDING

Empirical and intellectual sources behind the scenario

This book is speculative fiction and political philosophy, but several of its premises are intentionally anchored in contemporary debates and observed institutional trends. The sources below are not offered as proof of the fictional future. They identify the intellectual and empirical materials from which the scenario is constructed.

Freedom House. *Freedom in the World 2026: The Growing Shadow of Autocracy*. Washington, DC, 2026. The report records the twentieth consecutive year of global decline in political rights and civil liberties during 2025 while also emphasizing the resilience of many established democracies.

V-Dem Institute. *Democracy Report 2026*. University of Gothenburg, 2026; and *Democracy Report 2025: 25 Years of Autocratization — Democracy Trumped?* These reports document the contemporary wave of autocratization and deterioration in freedom of expression and institutional checks.

World Justice Project. *Rule of Law Index 2025*. Washington, DC, 2025. The 2025 release reports broad deterioration in rule-of-law measures, including constraints on government power, judicial independence, civic participation, expression, assembly, and fundamental rights.

Stanford Institute for Human-Centered Artificial Intelligence. *AI Index Report 2026*. Stanford University, 2026. Relevant chapters document the industry's dominant role in notable model development, rapid growth in compute capacity, increasing capital intensity, and declining transparency among several frontier developers.

United Kingdom Competition and Markets Authority. *Cloud Services Market Investigation, Final Decision*, 31 July 2025. The investigation identified significant market power and barriers affecting switching, interoperability, and competition in cloud infrastructure services.

European Commission. *Market investigations and preliminary findings concerning cloud computing services under the Digital Markets Act, 2025–2026*. The Commission examined whether leading cloud services function as important gateways and highlighted the strategic role of cloud infrastructure for AI and the European economy.

Council of Europe. *Annual Report 2025 on the supervision of the execution of judgments and decisions of the European Court of Human Rights*. Strasbourg, 2026.

This provides a concrete view of the institutional work required to translate rights judgments into state implementation.

European Court of Human Rights. Annual Report 2025. Strasbourg, 2026. The report documents the Court's caseload, judgments, violations, and institutional role, illustrating both the durability and the operational demands of transnational rights protection.

Yanis Varoufakis. *Technofeudalism: What Killed Capitalism*. London: Bodley Head, 2023. Varoufakis develops the thesis that digital platforms and "cloud capital" generate rent-like forms of dependence that justify the language of technofeudalism.

Evgeny Morozov. "Critique of Techno-Feudal Reason." *New Left Review* 133/134, 2022. Morozov challenges claims that capitalism has been superseded by a new feudal order and argues for more careful analysis of digital political economy.

Jeremy Gilbert. "Techno-feudalism or platform capitalism? Conceptualising the digital society." *European Journal of Social Theory* 27(4), 2024. Gilbert evaluates the technofeudal thesis and argues that platform capitalism may offer a more plausible framework for understanding the current regime of accumulation.

Shoshana Zuboff. *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism*. New York: PublicAffairs, 2019. Zuboff's analysis of behavioral data extraction, prediction, and intervention informs the book's treatment of informational power and the political consequences of dependency on digital infrastructures.

Nick Srnicek. *Platform Capitalism*. Cambridge: Polity, 2016. Srnicek provides a concise political-economic account of platforms, data, network effects, and concentration.

Albert O. Hirschman. *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1970. Hirschman's distinction among exit, voice, and loyalty is foundational to the book's treatment of domain competition, portability, and dependence.

Robert Michels. *Political Parties: A Sociological Study of the Oligarchical Tendencies of Modern Democracy*. 1911. Michels's "iron law of oligarchy" informs the recurring problem of organizational self-reproduction.

Martin Gilens and Benjamin I. Page. "Testing Theories of American Politics: Elites, Interest Groups, and Average Citizens." *Perspectives on Politics* 12(3), 2014. The article is relevant to the broader debate over unequal political influence in formally democratic systems.

Thomas Hobbes. *Leviathan*. 1651. Hobbes's account of sovereignty, protection, covenant, and obedience provides a historical counterpoint to the Council's claim that protection can legitimate authority.

John Stuart Mill. *On Liberty*. 1859. Mill's defense of liberty, individuality, and dissent informs the final chapter's treatment of social variation and epistemic error correction.

Karl Popper. *The Open Society and Its Enemies*. 1945. Popper's emphasis on fallibilism and the institutional possibility of correcting rulers is relevant to the book's reinterpretation of liberal safeguards as error-correcting mechanisms.

James C. Scott. *Seeing Like a State*. New Haven: Yale University Press, 1998. Scott's analysis of legibility and high-modernist schemes informs the discussion of how administrative systems simplify populations and can become blind to what their categories exclude.

Elinor Ostrom. *Governing the Commons*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1990. Ostrom's work complicates the binary between centralized states and private property by demonstrating durable forms of polycentric collective governance.

Douglass C. North, John Joseph Wallis, and Barry R. Weingast. *Violence and Social Orders*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2009. Their analysis of how political orders organize access, rents, and violence informs the book's concern with elite coalitions and institutional stability.

Daron Acemoglu and James A. Robinson. *The Narrow Corridor*. New York: Penguin Press, 2019. The book's account of liberty as emerging from a balance between state capacity and social power provides an important alternative to both weak-state romanticism and concentrated technocratic rule.

Michel Foucault. *Security, Territory, Population and The Birth of Biopolitics*. Lectures at the Collège de France. Foucault's concepts of governmentality and biopolitics inform the analysis of governance through data, risk, and the administration of populations.

Friedrich Nietzsche. *Thus Spoke Zarathustra; Beyond Good and Evil; On the Genealogy of Morality*. The fictional Council draws selectively on Nietzschean themes of self-overcoming, higher types, and critique of egalitarian morality. It does not treat Nietzsche as the author of a systematic technofeudal political program. Contemporary philosophical scholarship remains divided over whether Nietzsche offers any systematic political philosophy at all.

Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy. "Nietzsche's Moral and Political Philosophy," substantive revision 2024. This overview is particularly useful for distinguishing Nietzsche's anti-egalitarian moral critique from later attempts to construct a political system in his name.